

# SCREAM QUEEN

CHELSEA HATES LIBBY

1 of 3

KT MORRISON

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## ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

*Visit My Website!*

[ktmorrison.com](http://ktmorrison.com)

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

This book takes place in Canada where recreational use of cannabis is legal.

## **SCREAM QUEEN**

### **A Chelsea Hates Libby Serial Novella**

#### **Chelsea Hates Libby #1 of 3**

*33,000 words*

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## PROLOGUE

WHEN IT WAS ALL OVER, Ben Todd would ask himself how it happened—no, not how, but why. *Why* did it happen?

The awful events of that summer, the series of reproachful interludes that finally led to great calamity must have occurred for a reason.

The answer was in his house the whole time. Not out where he would see it, not in the face or the eyes of the woman he loved nor the one who ruined him. On the second floor of their rented Beaches home, in the room he used as his office, there was a box on the top shelf of the closet. In that box was a dusty old tome he hadn't looked at in probably seven or more years. A glossy bound book of no more than two hundred pages; and just past the halfway point, on page 105, on the right hand side, bottom half, a picture on the inside left would show the clue that could answer the ugly question of *why*.

The three collected faces of the yearbook committee.

It might not be the greatest answer—because what had happened was truly awful and ultimately unnecessary—but tales of this nature never have an answer you could call satisfactory. The best that could be mustered is a general: I guess that makes sense. Because human nature is unknown, and the cruelty of others never truly boils down to one reason; people are dark and you can never truly know how they interpret the actions and conversations around them. Sometimes their greatest acts of cruelty can appear meaningless and wanton, but to the mean girls of the world a settled grudge can taste like the sweetest soda pop...

PART 1  
BLOCK PARTY  
SATURDAY, JUNE 22

A PARTY WAS a great way to introduce yourselves to the neighborhood, so Ben and Libby held an open house on the first Saturday of summer, welcoming anyone from their modish beach neighborhood who'd like to drop by between three in the afternoon and ten at night. They had cold beer ready in coolers, punch, soda pop for anyone with kids, two tanks of propane for the barbecue, and in the fridge were four dozen homemade hamburger patties and a hundred and twenty hot dogs. A table on the back deck was festooned with bowls of chips, cheese, and veggies and dip, some deli meat, and pickles.

It had been almost four weeks since they'd moved in, and they'd met a lot of the neighbors and had been invited to a few dinners as well. But this open house was a 'thank you' to those who'd extended graciousness and a chance to get to know those they hadn't crossed paths with.

The house they were in was a narrow red-brick three-story with tight hallways and small rooms, but it was in the Beach Triangle, expensive, finely appointed, and while they were in the city, this neighborhood had a small-town feel where everyone knew everyone and watched out for each other. There were primo bars within walking distance, great shopping, great eating, and of course the scenic Kew Beach with its boardwalks and cafes.

Ben was out back on the deck raised up about four feet off the small square grass patch that served as their backyard wearing an apron Libby had bought him that said "Dinner Is Coming," underneath the Game of Thrones wolf emblem comically wearing a chef's hat. About twenty burgers and twenty dogs had been served over the last five hours and it was getting

near dinner time now. The turnout was good and friendly, and there was a happy churn of well-wishers and hopefully some future friends.

Libby was born for the duty of host, taking the job on earnestly. Ben knew she'd be committing everyone's name to memory successfully, making eye contact and generally charming everyone—and not just the guys, because despite her beauty she was *better* with women. It was her demure and gracious manner that made other girls feel easy.

While Ben manned the barbecue, he watched Libby flit around in an apron of her own that he'd bought her, hers black with white tuxedo markings. She moved in and out of the gathered clutches of people on their deck and in their kitchen and family room, making sure everybody had what they needed, making sure everyone knew what was available. Her silky blonde hair pulled back from her face, she wore just a touch of makeup today because she was expecting company. Nothing extravagant, just the slightest bit of color on her lips and a little black around her lashes. And he knew she must be very self-conscious about it, because she usually didn't have the vanity or enthusiasm to pull off a face with makeup. She liked to keep things *au naturel*. Under her apron she wore a light chambray shirt with a button-down collar. Earrings were small tasteful gold clamshells...

She caught him watching, gave him a funny and friendly wave, a summer camp theater gesture of *Hello!*, one hand on her hip the other drawing an arc like a rainbow, smiling at him. Light came in from the outdoors making the lenses of her tortoiseshell glasses wink at him like headlights from where she stood in the dim shade of the family room just beyond the sliding glass doors. He gave her a thumbs up, and she clamped white teeth on her pink tongue and gave him two back, wagging them awkwardly to show how pleased she was with the way the afternoon was going.

When all the burgers were gone from the cooler he had, he went back in the house and found her in the kitchen talking with two middle-aged couples, faces he'd seen on their own street. He swooped in with a hand on the small of her back and kissed her cheek. "How's it going, baby? Everything good?"

Libby patted his chest, said, "Have you met Mr. Meriwether?—and this is his wife, June."

"Not Mr. Meriwether," the man said, smiling, "just call me Mike."

“Mike, pleased to meet you.”

Libby now gestured with her hand toward the other couple, both of them women with short haircuts brushed back at the sides. She said, “Carol and Gwendolyn. They live at 58, you know, up the street and on the other side, the nice house with the brick entrance way.”

Ben shook their hands as well, saying, “You’ve lived in the neighborhood long?”

They told him it was just a few years now, but that they loved it and *never* wanted to move.

Libby said, “I know, we can’t believe we’re here. I’ve always wanted to live in the Beaches, it’s this guy,” she said, thumbing toward him, “that made it happen for us.”

He said, “I like to make Libby happy.”

That brought awww-ing from all four of them. Libby blushed, and it made Ben laugh then peck her cheek, and Mike said, “I hear you’re Northerners too.”

“Northerners too?”

Libby bumped him with the back of her wrist, said, “Aurora.” The town where they were both from.

“Oh, yes, right. We’re from Aurora too. Grew up there.”

Mike said, “Libby said you know Chelsea and Finn.”

He nodded slowly, saying, “I do. We do.”

Libby said, “We went to high school with Chelsea. We don’t know Finn.”

Mike’s wife, June, said, “Small world.”

Ben said, “Isn’t it?”

Carol said, “I ran into Finn yesterday at Casa Mia, he said they’d come by here today.”

Libby nodded, and Ben said, “Yes, we’re expecting them, or I mean, *hoping* they show up. Looking forward to it, we haven’t seen Chelsea in years.”

Mike said, “Bring you back to high school?”

Ben said, “Doesn’t *everything* bring you back to high school?”

Carol and Gwendolyn laughed, and Carol said, “You can *never* shake it.”

Libby looked glum, said, “Sometimes it’s like Lord of the Flies. Hard to believe they throw all us kids together like that.”

Now Ben jabbed a thumb toward his wife, said, “Look at this one, can’t have a conversation without referencing a book.”

“I love books,” Libby said, brightening.

Ben said to Mike, “She works at the big bookstore, the one down on—”

Libby corrected him: “Not the *big* bookstore. I work at the *good* bookstore...”

“It’s a pretty big store,” he said.

Libby said, “We’re not known for our size, we’re known for our customer service.”

Mike’s wife rolled her eyes comically toward her husband and muttered to him, “Sounds like you.”

When Carol and Gwendolyn laughed, Mike said, “Hey, come on, I’m known for *both*,” and took a swig of his beer.

The whole thing went over Libby’s innocent head, and she was still talking about the bookstore, saying how long she’d worked there.

And that was when Chelsea and Finn arrived.

STANDING in his front hall was the hottest girl in his high school. A four-year period—beginning twelve years ago—saw a teen Ben Todd with many a fantasy depicting him with sexy Chelsea Cunningham. Now Chelsea Slade. Back then there was no Finn in her life, but Chelsea had no shortage of boyfriends. She went through boys like a champ. Nothing but the best for old Chelsea. And why not, she was the most beautiful girl in their school, in fact, how about all five high schools that served the Aurora Township...

Not only beautiful, Chelsea had a reputation. An air of celebrity. Yes, she was a bitch, a first-class one, but she was respected and feared since they were little and it only grew more pronounced when she matured and she found a surprising career. Chelsea's mom (another Grade-A bitch, as his mother would often refer to her) had Chels competing in beauty pageants and singing contests since they were all in Grade One. Tried to get her on all the American shows, and she apparently auditioned once for American Idol but her segment never aired. Singing wasn't really her prominent thing, though she was talented. For Chelsea it was drama. Or movies more exactly. First year in high school, Chelsea got a part in a big-budget Hollywood movie that was shooting in Toronto. It was only a few minutes on screen but it led to a few more parts, one where she played the flashback teen version of Academy award-winning actress, Shelley Masters. Ben had watched that movie on a loop (at least part of it), because fifteen-year-old Chelsea—who he saw daily in real life—wore a bikini. There she was committed to film, a friend (kind of), showing off her tight body he used to wonder about at night. He watched her scene so many times he knew every heartbeat of her appearance, could recite her lines though there were

admittedly not many. And, frankly, he jerked off to the scene quite a few times as well. It was only a total of five minutes and thirty-eight seconds of cinematographic history, but it was a big bright spot in his masturbatory repertoire. Because here was this girl he knew saucing around poolside playing the part of a teen vixen that later went on to murder three men (who arguably deserved it) and get defended in court by Russell Crowe.

That part led to other Toronto productions, and because of her looks and her bad girl vixen portrayal in that big-time movie she was a shoe-in for any thriller or horror that came to film in the city. The last year of high school, a movie came out where Chels had a two-and-a-half minute flee-from-the-killer scene. It *shamed* the poolside scene for its wanton sexuality, and sometimes when he jerked off to it he lamented that she didn't shoot this one first and he could have enjoyed it when *all* he had was masturbating. Although they couldn't have done *those* scenes when she was fifteen. Because in this one—a pretty big budget eighties slasher remake—Chelsea showed bouncing bare breasts, bare ass, and holy shit, a half-second of bush. She was long-legged, insanely beautiful, and he used to study how her muscles moved against her skin as she ran in the dark shadows of an old summer camp unable to escape the machete-wielding murderer.

The weirdest part was day-in and day-out he saw that exact same tall girl in the halls of the school. And he'd gone to public school with her. Libby as well. So that meant when he and Chels passed in the halls—even though he wasn't any longer in her circle of friends—they had a grade one-through-seven history with each other that meant he wasn't her enemy. It meant she would occasionally flirt with him, even at one point had him twisting in his bed sheets thinking maybe she meant it when she said he was cute. As he got older, it became completely clear that Chelsea said that to just about everybody. Once they were separated by post-secondary, her proximal pussy power over him ceased and he realized how foolish he'd been to harbor such fantasies.

Now here she was: that girl that made his bed sheets sticky stood in his front hall, beaming at him, a devilish presence; outrageously and immediately sexy, tall and long-limbed, thick flowing honey-caramel hair in a tangled mane that fell around her shoulders and down to her waist...

"Welcome to the neighborhood, Ben," she sang in loud proclamation, holding a bottle of wine in each hand while her husband Finn plopped their motorcycle helmets on the deacon's bench.



He went to her like a gracious host. It'd been more than eight years since they'd seen each other, and he wasn't that dorky high school kid anymore. He was a college grad, one with a great business underway, one he'd conceived himself. He'd made a quarter-million last year—good enough he could afford to prop him and Libby up in a multi-million dollar beach house.

So as they got closer he felt confident and was happy to show her the new grown-up and *manly* Ben Todd. But as the distance between them shrank from a dozen feet to four all that confidence began to wane. She was *so* crazy beautiful.

She folded him in an embrace with a wine bottle still in each hand and hugged him hard. She said, "Oh, my God, it's so effin' great to see you, Ben—it's *crazy* that we live in the same neighborhood..."

"I know, isn't it?" His voice had gone high and solicitous. *Smooth*.

"We're going to have so much fun together."

"I hope so," he said, too soft and agog again.

"Hey," Chelsea said, stepping back, "Ben, this is my husband, Finn..."

"What's up, buddy," Finn said and extended a hand for a shake. "Welcome to the neighborhood, Ben."

"Thanks, Finn," he said.

Finn didn't look like the kind of guy he expected beauty queen Chelsea to end up with. The guy was good-looking, it wasn't that, he'd just imagined Chelsea with some big beefcake guy who wore a suit and worked on Bay Street. Maybe drove a top-of-the-line Mercedes. But Chels went the opposite route. Finn looked like a musician. He wasn't much taller than Ben, maybe an inch or two, and he probably wasn't more than a hundred-seventy pounds. Not some macho football jock type at all. He had tattoos all up and down both arms, full sleeves, tattoos on his neck, dark eyes, like a magician's eyes. He was kind of thin, narrow hips but with broad shoulders and big hands. And the guy didn't drive some Mercedes, he rode a motorcycle. Libby told him the other night, someone told her Finn worked as a big-time sound engineer at the Sony Center. He was the liaison that ran big shows for all the major bands that came through Toronto. The guy had a good handshake grip.

"All right, come on in," Ben said, ushering them into the kitchen. He stopped a second, said, "Hey, you know I married Libby, right?"

Chelsea said, "I know, I heard, Libby Sanders is now Libby Todd."

“It’ll be our third anniversary next month,” he said.

“Wasn’t exactly a surprise, Ben,” she said. “You guys were dating a long time.”

He agreed: “All through high school.”

“You guys were tight,” she said.

“She’s the light of my life, even today,” he said, heading down the hall and letting them follow behind, secretly wincing at the effete phrase: light of my life. *Not exactly cool, Ben.*

In the kitchen, Libby was still in congregation with Carol, Gwendolyn, and Mike and his wife. Their faces lit up seeing him escort Chelsea and Finn. Chelsea was a real-live celebrity.

“Hey, Finn, shit, man, good to see you,” Mike said, getting right in for a close handshake. Gwendolyn and Carol went glassy-eyed seeing Chelsea, saying in a harmonic singsong: “Hi-ii, Chelsea.”

But Chelsea went right for Libby, and Libby flinched. She’d been holding a glass of water with her arms folded across her stomach and seeing Chelsea coming close made her move her back against the kitchen counter and bring the glass up in between them protectively. Chelsea wasn’t deterred, practically cooing as she put her arms around Libby.

“Oh, Libby, oh, my God, look how beautiful you are. I haven’t seen you in so long...”

Chelsea was a half head taller than Libby, and Libby’s eyes blinked behind her glasses, looking up and shifting from side to side. “Hi, Chelsea,” she said quietly.

“Welcome to the neighborhood,” Chelsea said.

“I heard you were living here,” Libby said.

“Crazy coincidence, isn’t it?” Chelsea stood back from Libby now, holding onto her upper arms and looking her over.

She said, “Seriously, Libby, look at you...”

“You look... You look good, too,” Libby said with a creaky, unsure voice.

“Thank you, sweetheart. This is so damn crazy. We’re going to have real live friends right here in the neighborhood. I can’t believe it.”

Now Chelsea hooked an arm around Libby’s neck and stood side-by-side with her like they were best buddies, both of them leaning back on the counter. She said to her husband, “Finn, look at this. This is who I said was going to be my new best friend.”

Finn was talking close with Mike, and he looked up, smiled, said, “Libby, right?”

Libby blanched when her eyes met Finn’s, her mouth wormed around and she whispered, “You’re Finn?”

“Pleased to meet you, Libby,” Finn said and crossed to the two women. He took Libby’s hand in both of his, her small hand disappeared between them. He said, “Hey, it’s really so great to meet you. Chelsea says so many great things about you.”

“She does?”

“When Chels heard you were moving into the neighborhood, she was amped.”

“Amped?”

Chelsea said, “I was. God, Libby and Ben. Libby Sanders and Ben Todd. Sorry, Libby Todd now. Such a blast.”

Libby looked from Finn to Chelsea and back again, nervously tweaking on her nose.

AS THE EVENING WORE ON, Ben was called to his barbecue duty less and less. Just around dusk, a woman named Margaret showed up with her two kids, six and eight. She was a single mother, and lived outside the Triangle, but had friends who'd come by earlier. She was funny and a good sport about how haggard she was. He was glad to cook up hot dogs and hamburgers for her kids, and when she took them home about an hour and a half later, he sent them with leftovers. Then the BBQ was closed.

After six o'clock Libby reckoned it all right for the hosts to drink, and he had a beer, she had a glass of wine. He had a couple more beers and was pretty sure she might've topped up her glass once or twice afterwards as well. Her cheeks had blossomed rosy moons just below her big brown eyes. It had been a long and arduous day but one filled with fun and good cheer and he could see it in his wife's beautiful face.

When it grew dark, the older crowd seemed to thin, and they were left with people closer to their own age. Finn and Chelsea were still there and some other people they knew, and someone turned up the stereo. Libby asked if anyone thought it was too loud, and Finn said, "Everybody in the beaches is pretty cool, Libby." Then he presented himself to her holding out those two big tattooed hands, taking Libby's glass and setting it on the deck and hoisting her out of the lawn chair.

"Come on and dance with me, Libby, let's kick off the summer with some fun."

"I don't really dance," she laughed, those rosy blooms widening in circumference.

It got Ben laughing to see Lib so carefree. There was a lot she kept buttoned up, and it was good to see her let loose a little, have some fun like the regular people.

“Hold up,” Finn said, got his iPhone, flicked through it quick, then some old sixties surfer rock played on the stereo and Chelsea applauded his selection. He tossed his phone onto the picnic table where the bowls of macaroni salad and potato chips and veggie slices had diminished, clapped his hands and said to Libby in his fun-loving cool drawl, “Kick off your shoes, Lib.” Then he started to watusi, but a slowed-down expressionless *heroin* version that fit the music. It made Libby laugh then blush and turn away for a moment. She slipped her canvas Keds off. There was a woman called Amber jumping up now, joining in so it wasn’t just the two of them, taking Libby’s hands and showing her how to do it. He watched his wife loosen up a little. Watched her try to shimmy despite the fear and self-consciousness. One-to-maybe-three glasses of wine really suited her.

“Hey,” Chelsea said, “look at her go,” and she grabbed his forearm and patted it. The two of them were sitting still in deck chairs.

He said, “It’s good to see her kick it out a little.”

Chelsea shimmied her chair closer, said, “She was always so quiet.”

“I know. She’s happy in her shell.”

Chelsea clapped her long hands with the music, shouted, “Go, Libby!”

Ben joined her clapping, saying, “That’s it, baby!”

Lib had a concealed sexiness. She was petite in stature, but full-figured. Thin waist and wide hips, full breasts; what she had she kept tightly and modestly confined. It was only him who got to enjoy it—he only wished she liked to do it with the lights on. It was mostly his hands that got to experience her femininity.

Finn took Lib’s hands now, both of them wagging their hips back-and-forth and squatting down almost with their butts to the decking before corkscrewing themselves back up to stand. They laughed and bounced on their toes and Finn showed her some jerky arm movements he managed to somehow not look foolish performing. He was one of those cool guys who could keep a stone serious face, yet somehow let you know they were on the verge of breaking out laughing with you. He performed for Lib, getting her laughing, her silky hair swinging around her shoulders.

Chelsea said, “It really is good to have friendly faces in the neighborhood.”

“I’m glad you’re here too,” he said, leaning close.

She said, “Show me around your place.”

He said sure, thinking he’d slip in and grab a fresh beer, too, while Libby was occupied.

It was just the two of them in the kitchen and he asked Chelsea if she wanted another drink. She said she was good, but he popped another beer from the fridge anyway and handed it to her. When he withdrew one for himself, they clinked bottlenecks and took swigs. “All right, the grand tour. Now, you know, the place isn’t very big, so we’re going to be done in about forty-five seconds. Like this right here,” he said, wagging a finger around like helicopter blades, “this is the kitchen. That’s about it...”

They moved out of the kitchen. “There’s the family area,” he said, strolling, “this is the hall, you’ve seen this. There’s the front room...”

“What’s upstairs?”

He said, “You want to see upstairs?”

“Sure,” she said. “Hey, you guys buy or you renting?”

He shrugged, said, “We’re renting for now, but Lib loves the area, maybe we’ll buy something in a couple years.”

“Finn and I bought when we married, but we’d just come from B.C., and we got a lot for my place on the Island. Vancouver prices versus T.O.” She showed two hands, one suspending the bottle, moving up and down showing the balance of a close scale. “But my place in Van was a lot bigger.”

“I know, tell me about it. That’s why we’re renting now, a few more years we’ll have a family and, you know, what will we want then? This place is perfect for the two of us, but there’s only two bedrooms and an office.”

“And the *size* of the bedrooms...” She rolled her eyes.

“I know, I’ve been in bigger dorms.”

“Show me,” she said now, nodding her chin up the staircase.

He led the way, going up the stairs ahead of her and flicking on the light. He said, “That’s my office there, it’s got a balcony. If you go out and stand on it, you can see a bit of the lake.”

“Cool. You got a view of the lake?”

He laughed. “You have to go out and stand on the deck, and you have to lean out.”

“Let’s take a look,” she said.

He flicked the office lights on, went past his swivel chair and his monitor with its geometric patterns opening and folding across its blank surface while it slept. She was behind him and she asked him what he did.

“Buy and sell. I did two years of internships during business school and I found all these, what you’d call relationships, I guess, *contacts*. All overseas. I buy cheap luxury goods here, then sell high where there’s scarcity and demand.”

When he opened the door to the balcony, Chelsea flicked off the office lights. He looked back and saw her silhouette approaching him. She said, “Too bright.”

“What are you, a vampire?”

“I played one in a movie once,” she laughed.

“So you still do movies?”

“I’ll do parts whenever I’m offered, but I rarely audition,” she said, stepping out onto the balcony with him and then sliding the doors closed behind him. “Mostly I’m at the theater.”

He said, “You were always so great.”

“Thanks, Ben,” she said. “Yeah, after high school I went to L.A., then I came back, went to York, dropped out, then did a whack of movies here, B.C., Europe... Like eight in two years. Got married, came to The Six and figured I’d take a go ahead on whatever Canadian productions were going on, and I’d get my chops working the theaters. Now all I really care about is doing plays.”

“Hey, you remember when you did *Streetcar Named Desire*?”

“In Aurora?”

He asked waggishly: “Did you do it somewhere else?”

“I did.”

He laughed. “Of course you did, what am I thinking... Yeah, I meant at high school. You played Blanche...”

“You remember that?”

“Remember it?—you were awesome.”

“What was so awesome, Ben?” She set her beer bottle down on the railing.

He said, “I don’t know, it was just good to see somebody I knew who could do something so *well*. You know, like something you saw on TV or movies.”

“You think I was that good?”

“You were in *movies*, Chelsea. I saw *all* the movies you were in, at least when I knew you.”

“Did you really?”

“Of course I did.” Then sheepishly admitted: “All the guys watched your movies.”

“Ben, are you telling me you jerked it?”

He startled at her forward question. “No,” he said, “Uh, *no*.”

“I’m teasing, Ben, chill out,” she said warmly. Then: “But you probably did.”

“No, I didn’t,” he said, but laughed nervously.

His laugh made her laugh, and she said, “Uh-oh, sounds like you really *did* do it...”

“Get out of here,” he teased.

She studied his profile quietly, and he grew uncomfortable. “You were always so cute,” she said, and from the streetlights down on Sarah Ashbridge he could see her watching him. Her beautiful face turned toward his, lights catching in the underside of her eyes, the slight tug of a smile...

He said, “Yeah, sometimes you’d say that.”

“It’s true, it’d make me feel good seeing you in the halls.”

“I used to love seeing you in the halls,” he said quietly.

She sniffed a laugh, still watching him. “Tell me if you jerked it.”

“I didn’t,” he said, his throat getting tight.

“Why don’t you tell me for real. Don’t be shy.”

“No, I never did.”

“I bet that you did,” she said slyly, still staring at him.

He looked past her, pointed out on the horizon between a frame of tall maples and honey locusts lining his street, said, “See, look, you can see moonlight on the waves of the lake.”

Chelsea’s hand gently cupped him right between his legs, her clawed fingers gripping his bulge. He jumped back, his stomach muscles bouncing, a chuff of air escaped his shocked lips. He gasped, “What are you doing?...”



CHELSEA STUDIED HIM, eyes in narrow slits, her beautiful lips pulled in a foxy smile. Hands clasped together now, she leaned on the railing. “Relax, Ben,” she said. “I’ve wanted to do that for a long time.”

“Geez,” he said, “I don’t think you should...”

“You never wanted it?”

“I mean...”

“Just be honest—tell me you wanted it, Ben...”

“Course I did, I was a teenage boy in high school.”

“Yeah, I wanted it too. There were a couple guys I always had questions about...”

He was quiet as his mind raced. Traffic from the beaches washed their city sounds through the muffling trees and he could hear the lake on the cool wind coming from the south. He licked his lower lip in the dark. “What kind of questions?”

She tossed her hands, let them drape. “Guys I just never got to spend enough time with but that I thought about sometimes.”

He looked at her sideways, but only saw the caramel sweep of her hair. “I was one of those guys?”

She turned her face to him. “You sure were, Ben. I thought about you a lot.”

He nodded. “We went to public school together, we knew each other a long time.”

“Yeah I know, it was more than that, more than... *fondness*, I guess. There were a lot of things I wanted to do with you. You were so cute—sorry, *are*, you still *are*.”

A tightness worked in his stomach from having a surprise fondling of his genitals. His testicles ached from the flinch—the boys had tried to jump back inside his body when she'd touched them. But now her words had produced a new response down there: he'd grown hard.

He chewed his lower lip, said, "What did you want to do?"

"At school? I thought about you a couple times." She looked back at the view over the treetops.

"Thought about me how?"

She faced him. "You had—*have*—a nice smile, Ben. You're a nice guy. A decent guy."

"Doesn't sound so exciting..."

"I dunno, Ben. You meet a lot of guys who you think are going to be amazing, you know, big muscular jock types. Then they put you to sleep. They're way more into themselves than into pleasing you."

"What are we talking about here?"

"Fucking, Ben. I was with a couple of guys from our school who were all show and no go. Makes a girl wonder about some of the *other* guys she meets. Not the ones who are selling themselves, getting in your face and putting on the man show. The ones with the cute smiles who you *know* would kill for you."

He smirked. "You think I would kill for you?"

"In high school you would," she laughed.

"I don't know about that," he said. *It was possible*. "Yeah, you coulda got me to do things for you."

"Carry my book-bag?"

"I would've done that," he said, giving her a sidelong glance and noticing she'd moved closer again.

She said, "If I'd have done that in high school, what would've happened?"

"Done what?"

"Grabbed your dick like that. What would you do to me?..."

His heart rate doubled, and he felt its beat in his eyeballs. *Probably grab your tits then come in my pants*. "I don't think we should talk about that..."

"It's just conjecture, Ben. What do you think would've happened?"

He chewed on his lower lip again knowing he should dart back into the house and get back down to join the party and avoid this awful situation. But instead, he said, "I imagine you could have got me to kill for you."

“I bet you’re good in bed,” she said.

His stomach bounced and the urge to flee ricocheted around the cavern of his skull. “You do?”

“I totally do. That’s how I pictured it. Like you know some of those guys, remember Ronnie?...”

“That guy was such an asshole.”

“Ronnie had an *unbelievable* body, but I’m serious, Ben... Total dud in the sack. I caught him flexing one time while we were fucking. You know? Like I mean making one of those bodybuilder biceps and looking at his own arm—can you picture that?” She posed for him, cranking up her long thin arm and flexing.

“What a tool.”

She kissed her bicep, laughed, slunk her arms back over the railing. “Total tool. So into himself.”

“Yeah, no, you’re right, I would be into you, not myself.” His voice felt like a distant friend prancing in a field alongside him, autonomous but unsure.

Chelsea said, “That’s how I pictured it. That’s why I was asking about you jerking off to me...”

He laughed, and it came out a little more nervous and girlish than he’d expected. The sound made her laugh too. She said, “Relax, I just think you and I had something that never got explored but should have. I was asking because...” She paused, looked down to the driveway. “I did it a couple times thinking about you.” She turned her face to him again, blank and open.

He stared at her, watched her eyes move up his body to meet his gaze. “Did you?”

“A couple times I did.”

“Okay,” he said. “I might’ve done it too...”

“There’s that sweet honesty I would expect from Ben Todd. Too bad those high school days are *gone*, buddy boy.”

“Uh-huh,” he mumbled, feeling a tightness in his chest that was making it hard to breathe. His cock had reached full hardness in his pants, and it seemed to catch up funny in his underwear. He ached to tug his pants and straighten it out. “No, those days are long gone. It’s too bad we’ll never know,” he said, nodded, his elbows on the balcony railing and looking out at the way the moonlight wavered on Lake Ontario.

Her arm was touching his now, both of them with their elbows on the railing. Then her hip was against his, her thigh touching his as well. He stopped breathing, his eyes grew wider. *There was no way this was even happening.* Now she turned to face him while he still looked out over the view. Her hand caressed his arm, went down the small of his back, slipped inside the pocket of his cotton shorts. She turned her hand sideways, and through the thin material of his pocket, the hardness of her nails raked over his pubic pad. “Whoa, Chelsea...”

But it was too late, her fingertips prodded his erect penis pointing her way. She said, “I thought so. I always knew Ben Todd would get good and hard for me.”

With her fingers still touching his penis and sending an electric wildfire through his brainstem, he muttered, “Some of those guys didn’t?”

“Steroids,” she said, “drinking too much, maybe deep down they were scared they couldn’t back up how great they bragged they would fuck me... I don’t know, whatever other reasons, they might only be able to fuck once a night. Twice if I was lucky. I figured Ben Todd could go all night long, that he might be a lover rather than a banger.”

He nodded, trying hard to breathe without making a desperate sound that she would hear. His heartbeat pounded in his neck. He said, “I would have. I would have given one of my balls to fuck you all night.” Soon as he said the F word, he knew it was too far. That was something he shouldn’t have done. “I’m sorry,” he said.

“No, Ben. I like to hear you be honest.”

“I would’ve done anything for you back then,” he said.

“You should’ve gone for it,” she whispered, “or I should’ve...” She removed her hand from his pocket and he ached to have it back between his legs. He wasn’t even thinking straight, the pulse in his steel rod blotting out any moral sense he might have.

“We, uh, should go back down...”

“We should,” she said draggily, the way she ended her sentence leaving something hanging.

“Shouldn’t we?”

“We could go back down, Ben, or we could do what *I* want to do which is take that dick out and suck it.”

“Oh, ho-ho, ho,” he coughed, almost folding in half hearing the erotic words from her. “I don’t...”

Now she was facing him again, using her left hand to stroke at his stomach and then pat her palm over the hump of his erection.

She said, "I want to feel how hard Ben Todd gets."

"I get hard," he told her.

"Take it out."

"I can't..."

She whispered, "I'll do it..."

CHELSEA'S HANDS moved between his legs and drew down his zipper. The sound was so loud all he could think was that Libby would hear it downstairs on the back deck even over top of her surfer rock music.

"Chelsea..."

"Just let it happen, Ben..."

"We're both married..."

Now her hand was inside the open fly of his pants, weaving in underneath the front waistband of his shorts. He gasped as her fingertips snaked through his pubic hair.

"Whoah, oh-ho, there it is," she said as her grip—Chelsea fucking Cunningham's god damn grip—went around his cock. Holy shit, he literally *would* have killed for her in high school, literally *would* have given one of his testicles to be with her... His hand came down, tugged a yawning opening in his fly and she pulled his dick out.

"Yeah, I bet you could fuck me a dozen times in one night..."

"I totally could," he said, "I totally could," his voice trailing off.

Chelsea lowered, squatting down next to him. He pushed his hips back, she got between him and the balcony railing.

"Oh, shit," he sighed, feeling her mouth go over his cock and sink him inside her.

He groaned, eyes closing, head coming down, feeling Chelsea bob up and down on him. Chelsea Cunningham was blowing him. It was unfucking-believable. He sighed and panted, hearing Chelsea's mouth sounds as she sucked his cock. The slurping, the blurted suction sounds as she drew her head back too far. But she was eager, sinking him back inside her mouth

right away again, using her thumb and a finger to stroke him a little, her other hand slipping in and squeezing on his balls.

He jerked and writhed with the insane and overpowering pleasure. Chelsea's mouth was at the expert level, and he hadn't had a blow job since he was nineteen, during the year-long gap when he and Lib took a break. That slick, greasy velvet feel, that tug of her mouth's suction, the slip of her tongue...

And in two minutes it was all over.

"Oh, shit, oh, no, I'm gonna come," he panted.

Instead of pulling back, Chelsea Cunningham—the hottest girl in his high school!—bopped faster and made happy humming sounds in her throat.

"I'm going to come, mm, in your, mm-mouth," he said.

He heard her hum an Uh-huh and squeezed his balls again, harder.

"Oh, God, oh, shit..." And it was done, he was ejaculating inside the prettiest girl in the whole town he grew up in. She snorted through her nose, drawing in long breaths as she drank everything he pulsed over her tongue. "Oh, God," he grunted and coughed, "oh, God, oh, God, oh, God..."

At last it was over and the awful whooshing roar in his ears waned. His dick was still in her mouth, she was still squatted down on her heels with her knees poked out on either side of his calves. Instant shame settled over him like a greasy food sickness. His stomach turned over, and the urge came to throw up onto the walk below their front door. "Oh, no," he moaned.

The wet ring of her lips slid the length of his shaft, getting him trembling. She kissed the very tip of his penis and giggled, gripped his belt to pull herself up to stand right in front of him. Now they were face-to-face and he could look in her eyes.

"Hey," she said taking her index finger and bringing his chin up. She looked deep in his eyes, said, "Our little secret."

"We shouldn't have done that."

"Too late now, Ben. I hope you don't have regrets because I sure don't. Tell me something..."

"What," he said morosely.

"If it was just you and me here right now would you take me in your bedroom?"

"I'm married."

“Say we weren’t married—talk dirty to me.”

“I can’t.”

“Sure you can, Ben. Tell me what I want to hear...”

“What do you want to hear?...”

“Tell me how you can go all night.” She draped her straight arms over his collar.

“I could,” he said.

“That’s so hot...”

“I would. I could do it all night with you...”

“Libby doesn’t do it like you want?”

“I don’t want to talk about Lib...”

“Oh, don’t be sad. It’s just our little secret. I swear to God, Ben.”

“It’s just between you and me?”

“You and me. Our little secret. Something we should’ve done in high school but we just never got around to.”

“I wish we did it in high school.”

“I do too. Something tells me,” she said, a hand slinking down and grabbing his wet dick. “Yep, I knew it. You’re still hard.”

“We should go downstairs.”

“Yeah, we should. Too bad, too bad... if it was just me and you, say Libby went off to Vegas with her girlfriends, tell me you wouldn’t take me into your bedroom, fuck me till the sun was coming up.”

“I would...”

She slipped a ring of thumb and finger up and down his erection. “Say it.”

“I’d fuck you till the sun comes up.”

“Good. Good, Ben,” she said. “That’s enough. You’re right, we’re married.” She pushed his erection back into his underwear, zipped up his fly, cocking her head from side to side trying to get him to look at her, but he was afraid.

“It wasn’t a mistake,” she whispered, patting the cotton hump of his erection. “But we should get back downstairs before our spouses suspect I’m up here sucking your cock.”



WITH LIBBY UPSTAIRS, Ben took care of the cleanup. After the last guests had departed, he escorted his pretty Libby to the stairs and told her he would take care of everything. Told her to go and have a bath, sit in some hot water. She looked at him like he was crazy, but it was such a good idea she couldn't say no.

The idea of being alone with her right now scared the shit out of him. Everything inside him was on fire.

*He'd cheated on his wife. He fucking loved Libby more than anything...*

He never ever was going to do that in his whole life, and that was one thing that he was sure of. He and Libby had been best friends since they were eight and boyfriend-girlfriend since they were fifteen. There was that one time just after high school in their first year of college he'd got a little crazy what with all the stress and they broke up for one year. He dated two other girls in that time, but he'd been miserable without the sweetness of his Lib. In that year-long break Libby did nothing but study and be a good girl—no other boys for his shy girl. Somewhere in that thirteen month long hiatus he realized what a piece of shit he was and what an awesome human being Libby was, and that he needed her desperately.

Now here they were at the shoreline of troubled waters. And Libby had her back turned and had no idea how fast the current was thrashing. How had it come to this?

He was bent over the counter, forearms resting on the lip of the sink, eyes on the drain plug under all that soapy gray water. He wanted to shrivel up and slide right into that sink, shrink down to Ant-man size, hop into the drain, swim deep till he got sucked down into the city sewage system. That

was what he deserved. Libby was the sweetest girl on the planet, and she married a piece of shit. Piece of shit like every other guy out there that she feared. Ben Todd was supposed to be one of the good ones. Even Chelsea had said it—but look what happened.

*You were a good person until the right motivation came along. Like that hot girl from high school you pined for for years in that sick, feverish time where your sexuality was being hammered shape, plunged into the forge and hammered again and again.*

With a damp tea towel, he wiped his brow, hung it on the hook. He popped the plug and let the water go down the drain. The dishwasher was loaded and running, the bigger serving platters done by hand. All the empties sorted and put in their proper receptacles to be returned or to go out to recycling. Libby was upstairs still, probably in her bath, thinking what a great evening it had been. And even now with all this work done, he was frightened to go up and spend time with her; frightened to look her in the eyes.

After his oral tryst with Chelsea Cunningham—Chelsea *Slade*—the two of them had finished their upstairs tour without looking at the bedroom, Chelsea getting ahead and going down the stairs, him following sheepishly behind. Out on the back deck, Libby was having fun. It ached in his heart to see her so oblivious to the bad that had just transpired. Because she was dancing with Finn and Gwendolyn, the three of them moving on now to a twisted Chubby Checker electronic remake, Finn showing her how to do some elaborate new-style mashed potato. Libby had her sleeves rolled up, her apron off, her cheeks were flushed with color, her eyes bright and lively.

When she saw him coming, she put her arms out, and he joined her, not much of a dancer to begin with, the heavy weight on his heart made it impossible to get into it. He tossed himself into a lawn chair, brushed it off like he just had no rhythm. Truth was, he was dying inside. Chelsea had no chagrin. Taking a sip off a glass of wine, setting it down then joining in the dance party, getting behind her husband, kissing his neck and his ear as they danced together with Libby.

Ben shut off the kitchen lights, trying to think of other ways to stall before going upstairs, but there was nothing left to do. He resigned himself, head hanging low, mounted the steps and went into their bedroom.

Their en-suite bathroom door was open, and he passed through a wet fog of hot bathwater air. Libby was in their narrow walk-in closet wearing

her bathrobe, her feet bare. He asked her how her bath was.

She jumped like she didn't hear him coming, her hand over her heart and then laughed. "You're silent like a cat," she said. "You can't be serious—everything is cleaned up?"

"Platters drying in the rack, the dishwasher's on, food stored away... outdoors is tidy, doors locked..."

"You are ah-mazing," she sang in a little tune.

It hurt him to see her so happy, not knowing that horrible thing that her husband had done tonight. He leaned on the doorjamb to watch her. It occurred to him that he could reveal the badness, but he was in no way ready for the devastation that would cause. Not just seeing the hurt that it would stab into his beloved wife, but knowing this evening would be wrecked, her probably packing her bags and leaving for the night, probably getting her sister to come pick her up to take her to stay with her or her parents. *Or kicking him out.* Telling him to get out, and him staying with his brother for a week until she was ready to talk. And Libby was straight-laced and by the book. Talking would mean it was most likely time to separate.

Libby was selecting pajamas, and he watched his most favorite person in the world as she picked her cotton flannel PJ pants with the teddy bears on them. Always demure, she kept her robe on and put her legs through them with her back turned to him.

Truth was, he didn't have sex with Chelsea.

Sure, what had happened would end a marriage. But like Chelsea said: it was their secret. The two of them could pretend that it happened in high school, not tonight when they were both twenty-five now and married. Chelsea said it was something that should've happened a long time ago. Maybe they could just pretend it was in the past. Or at least he could.

Libby turned her chin over her shoulder, said, "Are you watching me get dressed?"

"Sorry," he said. "Zoned out. You want me to leave?"

She kind of smiled and gave him a funny face, said, "You don't have to." Then she dipped her shoulder down so she could get their eyes to meet. She said, "Is it all right if we don't have sex tonight?"

His eyebrows raised. He said, "I wasn't standing here thinking that."

"It's just... you're watching me get changed."

"I was lost in thought, just thinking about tonight. No, we don't have to. I *like* watching you..."

“Well, that’s okay,” she laughed. “You can watch.”

Now she shimmied out of her robe and let it fall to the floor. Her back was to him and he watched her shoulder blades and the slim muscles of her back work as she pulled a T-shirt over her head. He saw the creamy backside curves of her breasts as they swayed while she shrugged the T-shirt down and pulled it to her hips. Now she turned and faced him. Her nipples had hardened out humps in the pale cotton and his arms were out to receive her and hug before he even realized what was happening.

How could he betray this angel?

When they embraced the hurt came rolling back into his life. He did, he *betrayed* this beautiful and wonderful woman. He betrayed the most important person in his life. How could he ever make it up to her? Would telling her the truth make her life worse or better?

He swayed with her and she asked, “Was I a good dancer tonight?”

He laughed. “It was great to see you have fun.”

“Chelsea’s husband Finn seems like a pretty good guy.”

“You had fun with him?” Moving that conversational chess piece just opened him up to her counter move: *did you have fun with Chelsea?* And would he be able to lie if Libby confronted him?

But she said, “I always thought Chelsea didn’t like me, but I have to say we had a pretty good time tonight, don’t you think?”

“We did. I think we were excellent hosts.”

“You were great on the barbecue.”

“You were great with everything else, I mean it, Libby. I love you so much...”

“Aww,” she cooed, pushed them apart so she could look in his eyes. He half-smiled and she darted a kiss to his lips. She said, “Would you rub my back?”

“I’d be honored to rub your back, Libby. Hop on into bed.”

Libby disappeared from the closet and he heard the bed squeaking. Then he took off his own things and threw them in the hamper. He turned his underwear right side out, worried that there would be stains visible. He would have to get on the laundry first thing in the morning.

When he donned his PJs, he joined his wife in bed, found her sleepily on her stomach, arms folded up on the pillow, cheek resting on them. She had a happy smile on her face and he decided that he would have to keep what happened from her.

It never, ever even happened...

PART 2  
MILLION DOLLAR BOAT

WEDNESDAY, JUNE 26

THERE WAS a wealthy man in Dubai Ben believed would buy the boat he was here to see and make him sixty grand richer in the process. He was at the Boone Dry Dock in the Port Lands, on the eastern side of the waterfront where things remained more utilitarian. The Dry Dock was a ship repair and storage facility, a ship junkyard in some ways, and the guy who owned it, Earl E. Chambers, had snatched up three small yachts before they'd gone up for police auction where Ben would have had a chance at them. But he had a probable buyer for one of them, and he'd deal with Early (as he liked to be called), and still make a profit. The boats had been seized from some sort of organized crime element—he'd heard Russians—and Earl had the contact to get the jump on first choice. He'd probably slipped someone down at Metro Police the right amount of cash to get the heads up. But it was Ben Todd who had the connections to get full price and get it fast. So he'd pay Early's markup, and in about two weeks of back-and-forth phone calls he'd finally ship one of these babies off to the Middle East somewhere. If not, there was someone in Taiwan who might be interested.

So he was walking between the alleys of towering junkyard boats—sleeves rolled up, laptop under his arm, tie over his shoulder and sunglasses on—and he came around a forty-foot Chris-Craft that had to have been a real hoot in the early nineties but nobody in S.A. would be caught dead in. Next to it, however, was the sleek and beautiful yacht he was here for, lifted up, high and dry. That was when he saw the woman.

Straight ahead, on the step-up ramp that led to the Chris-Craft, there was a slender girl with honey-blond hair and cowboy boots sitting in the shade. She'd arrived by motorcycle, but he barely registered it, only noting

it was fat and low, bulky and custom looking, maybe an Indian. She had a bottle of bright red cream soda with two straws in it. It was such an incongruent sight he did a comedic double take. The girl was looking down and hadn't seen him yet. But here he was in this derelict chamber of dead nautical souls, creeping between dried out boats all by himself and coming to find what had to be a beautiful girl.

Then she turned, and he saw it was Chelsea.

The reaction was strange, because he brightened, smiled, his hand darting up to wave—then the events of the block party came down over his eyes like a blanket somebody was trying to suffocate him with. *Shit*. His hand fell, and he looked around to see if anyone was watching.

"Hey, Ben," she said, set down her soda pop and waved.

"Chelsea?... What are *you* doing here?"

She tapped something on the step next to her, like she was putting out a cigarette. Weed smell rode the draft channeled between the two big boats.

She said, "What a coincidence. I was down here looking for a boat and then *you* come walking along..."

"W-what?..."

She put an elbow on her knee and planted her narrow chin in her palm, cocked her head at him. "Really, Ben?"

He smirked and rolled his eyes. "I'm kind of stupid, huh?"

"I've been waiting for you, Benjamin."

"How'd you know where I was?"

"Aren't you going to come any closer?"

"Sure." He slowly sauntered to close the distance between them. About six feet apart, he leaned his shoulder on the curved hull of the Chris-Craft. "What's up?" he said, trying to sound cool—at least cooler than he'd sounded the night of the block party. She was phenomenally beautiful. That perfect face tilted up toward his, her slender shoulders showing because she had the sleeves of her threadbare Motörhead T-shirt rolled right up to her collar. Her jeans were tight and her cowboy boots looked like they were alligator and might cost a thousand dollars. He shifted uncomfortably; the girl was far too sexy.

After staring at him for a long moment she finally said, "Libby told me where I could find you."

"What?... You talked to Libby?"

"I went by your house this morning, you weren't there."



“You were looking for me?”

“I had a coffee with your wife. She said you’d be out here mid-morning looking at boats.”

“What did you tell her? What did you say you wanted me for?”

“I made up some bullshit. Told her I was looking for props from the theater and I thought with all your connections you might know someone.”

“But that’s... You have guys that specialize in that...”

She shrugged, made sleepy eyes. “Think Libby knows that?”

“I don’t know. What do you want me for?”

“Ben, Ben, Ben,” she sighed in dramatic fashion, like she was trying to calm him down. “It’s our secret—remember? I’m not fucking with you or anything, I’m not some crazy stalker. You think giving you a blowjob was like such a great experience for me I can’t stop thinking about it, aching to give you another one?...”

“No, I don’t think that.”

“I look like a stalker? You think I go kooky over a man?”

He said, “No, you look like you *have* stalkers.”

“I’ve had stalkers,” she said. “It’s no fun. I’m not a stalker, Ben. Just wanted to hang out with you.”

“I’m working.”

“I got the day off,” she said.

“You went by the house?” He wanted to clarify that, showing her a troubled face.

“Lib and I had a coffee before she had to go to work. She said you’d come down here to the Port Lands.”

“Did you say anything else to her?”

She shook her head, giving him a Get real face. Now she tilted her face up to look at the sky above the hulking boats. “I thought I’d come down here. You know I filmed a movie right across the street?”

“No. Where?”

“They shoot movies at the Hearn. Actually, wait—I’ve filmed there *twice*.”

“What’s that?”

“The old generating station, you drove right by it.”

“It’s derelict.”

“Not really. A movie company owns it. It looks good on film that way.”

“Cool,” he said, shifting from foot to foot then stuffing his nervous hands in his pockets because he didn’t know what to do with them and the grip on his laptop was getting sweaty.

She studied his anxiety. “Seriously, Ben,” she said, getting her sexy eyes thin again. She smirked like there was some hidden joke.

“What’s so funny?”

“You really think I showed up here to get you inside one of these boats so we could fuck?”

“I don’t know...”

“Ben, come *on*,” she said, making her eyebrows tent in the middle. “I’m not looking for a prop, I’m looking for a set. Lib said you were out looking at boats. I really *am* considering a set. I got a buddy who’s in a play with me who’s making a film. It’s kind of like a music-video-performance-art piece, but I know he wants it to be nautical. Libby said you were gonna be here, I popped by, told the old guy at the front I was looking for you, and he let me in.”

“Okay,” he said, feeling foolish enough his cheeks went a little warm.

“Really, Ben,” she said coyly, eyes narrowed in admonishment but smiling still. “I’m not here to fuck you. Get *over* yourself...”

“All right,” he said laughing now, “look, what happened between us I feel really bad about...”

“You didn’t like it?”

“No, it’s not that. Just I don’t want to *cheat* on my wife...”

“You didn’t. That happened in high school, right?”

He said, “It didn’t happen at all.”

“Right. It didn’t happen at all,” she said, face more serious, nodding. “We only both *thought* about it.”

He watched her staring at him, this way-too-beautiful girl, the both of them in a quiet secluded space where no one was watching him. He looked around behind him, saw no one, and ahead of them no one. The boat yard was empty. He said, “What kind of boat is your friend looking for?”

WITH BEN'S hand gestured outward, Chelsea climbed the stairs ahead of him and stepped onto the open back-deck of the eighty-foot Pershing he was looking to buy. He joined her, but she turned and walked away, running her fingers over the white leather, coming to the slid-open smoky glass door and slipping inside. Sunlight beamed off the all-white trim making him squint even behind his sunglasses.

He followed, found her in the yacht's luxurious belly looking over all the brushed aluminum, the hardwood, the glossy black spaceship controls.

"Shit, Ben, this is a *beautiful* boat. You going to buy this?"

"Not me. My company. I have a partner, too. We buy and sell high-end stuff. Both of us have contacts and we pool our resources to buy hot items and then—"

"You keep the markup."

"We keep the markup," he said. He set his laptop, folders, and phone down on the low chrome coffee table, put his hands in his pockets. "So you think it's a beautiful boat?"

"It's bad-ass, Ben, and you *know* it. Who's going to buy it?"

"A guy I know in Saudi Arabia."

"Oh, yeah? You ever go out there?"

"Once or twice a year."

"That's cool. I spent six months there."

"No shit?"

"Maybe we know the same people."

"Maybe."

"Your people rich-ass Arabs?"

“They are.”

“I thought so.”

Now he walked around her, moving into the kitchen, saying, “This the kind of boat your friend wants? Because I’ll probably ship it in about ten days... do you think he could get his video wrapped up in that time?”

“Beats me,” she said, her back to him, still admiring the boat’s luxury interior. He looked over his shoulder and studied her sexy figure; the slender grace of her arms; the swooping silk of her honey hair; the way that ass fit in those slim-fit jeans. Her legs went on *forever*...

She moved around now, her cowboy boots making clopping sounds in the small space. “You want me to ask him?”

“Can you call him? I might be able to buy him a couple more days when I do my deal here, but I gotta know...”

Chelsea spun on her heel, still looking around as if it was *her* deciding whether to buy the boat or not. She closed the distance between them, stopped right in front of him and leaned a hand out on the kitchen counter, staring in his eyes.

He asked quietly: “What are you thinking?”

“I think I want to test out the bed.”

“He needs the bed in the video?”

“What video?”

“Your friend’s performance art thing...”

“What friend?”

“The friend you said you’re coming out here for...”

“Sweet Ben,” she said, reached up and cupped his cheek. “Sweet Ben the nice guy...”

“I am nice,” he said.

“I don’t have any friend who wants to make a video.”

“You don’t?”

“You’re right, they have people for those things...”

“So what do you want?”

“I told you I came to test out that bed...”

“What are you saying?”

“Test it out with me, Ben,” she said, ran her fingernails down his arm, tickling his forearm hairs and then grabbing his hand and intertwining their fingers. “Come on, we’ll see if this bed can hold up...”

“Wait,” he said, but she was pulling him, walking ahead, making him turn around, hand gripped tight on his. When he resisted, she turned on her heel and began pulling him backwards.

“Come on, Ben. Show me how you fuck...”

“I can’t,” he said.

“So you’re as useless as Ronnie and all those other jerks from high school?”

“No...”

“You better than them or are you the same as them?”

“Better.”

“So come on and fuck me. Show me, Ben Todd. Fuck me.”

“I can’t, Chelsea.”

She raised an eyebrow. “Can’t get it up?”

“It’s not that...”

She released him, but with one stride slunk her body up against his, hand between them and grabbing a handful of his hard goods. He went up on his tiptoes as she squeezed his balls too tight. A smile curled up her cheeks, and she said, “This little guy betrays you at every turn.

“It’s not little.”

She laughed, said, “I meant compared to the rest of you, Ben. Your dick is great. It was the perfect size for sucking.”

“Okay,” he said, unsure, watching those confident eyes of hers knowing her vast history of sexual experiences.

“Our secret, Ben. Come on, come show me this bed...”

Now she pulled him by the erection, her hand squeezed over the front of his pants.

“Don’t, Chelsea,” he said, taking two steps being led by his dick but now holding onto her wrist. “I can’t...”

“Don’t you want to have fun, Ben?”

“Of course I do.”

“You already did it once. I told you I’m not going to tell anybody.”

“I love my wife.”

“I love my husband too. I’m not asking you to run off with me, make me an honest woman, Ben. I wanted to fuck you since high school, and you wanted it too. Both of us *want* it, why are you being such a dick?”

“Chelsea, please, I’m not being a dick.”

She eyed him sleepily again, cocking her head, letting his dick go and taking a step back. Now he watched her hands gather at her waist and she popped the top button on her faded Levi's. Then one by one she undid the flight of buttons, and he could see that underneath those jeans she wore no underwear. His eyes were glued to that triangle of skin being revealed. *The things he would've done to be with her when he was a teenager...*

She came a little closer again, gripped his shoulders, then her nails ran down his arms again until she held his hands. "What are you so afraid of?"

"I'm not afraid of anything."

"Are you a man?"

"I am."

"What man turns this down?"

"I love my wife."

She brought his right hand between them and put it down the front of her pants. And even though he didn't want to, he couldn't help himself. His fingers slipped down and explored the softness of her shaved mound. She said, "Put a finger inside me, Ben."

"Why?"

"Can you believe you're about to finger Chelsea Cunningham?"

"No."

"Put a finger inside me, find out how wet you made me."

He groaned, his moral consciousness blotting out again. The room was still and quiet, the city sounds of traffic seeming so far away. He slipped his two middle fingers between the cloven hump of her sex, finding her greased and eager, slipping deeper into her pants, curling between the cleft of her vulva.

"I'm wet, aren't I?" She smiled wide and bit gently on her lower lip.

"You are..."

She whispered, "Put your fingers inside me."

"Shit, Chelsea."

"Just do it, Ben, don't let me down."

Now he bit at his own lip—and slowly sunk both middle fingers up inside the hottest girl in his high school. His fingers entered inside her body, pushing apart that most intimate and heavenly part of her. She made an odd purring sound that got his cock flexing in his underwear.

"Tell me you don't want to fuck me, Ben."

"I can't..."

“Tell me you don’t want to.”

“Of course I want to.”

“I’m not going to tell anybody, Ben.”

“It’s not that.”

She shot a hip out, making his fingers slip around inside her, the slippery feel of Chelsea Cunningham’s insides making him lightheaded. “You’ve got to be the hardest guy to get into bed that I’ve ever met,” she said. “You really play hard to get.”

“Chelsea, come on, don’t.”

Both hands on his wrist, she guided his hand out of her pants. She stepped back, smiling broadly, tilting her head, then crossing her hands in front of her and pulling her T-shirt off. She wore no bra, and he saw what she looked like topless.

“Holy shit,” he sighed.

Her breasts were flawless smooth creamy-flesh globes that barely sagged. The nipples were dark, pinkish but mostly a caramel color that matched her hair. They were full and perfect and it was ten times better seeing them like this instead of bouncing around in that quick-edit rampage where they bounced up and down and around as she fled the killer and his machete. A weakness seized his legs, and he felt like he might drop.

She said, “You ever dream about this?”

“Uh-huh...”

Now she thumbed down her pants, seesawing her hips, using the instep of her boots to pry off the heels and stepping out of her jeans, getting totally naked now in this multimillion dollar boat he was going to buy.

“Tell me you don’t want to fuck me,” she said, standing completely naked, the most outrageously beautiful woman he’d ever seen.

“I want to fuck you.”

“Show me how this bed works, Ben. You going to fuck me in the belly of this million-dollar boat?”

“Four million.”

“There’s my man,” she said, dipping her chin. “You gonna buy this boat today, you badass?”

“I am.”

“You going to fuck me in this boat today?”

“I am,” he said.

“COME ON AND DO IT, show me how Ben Todd fucks,” she said, turned on a bare heel, marched out of the galley and stepped down to the mid-ship master state-rooms’s door, that beautiful ass swaying from side to side.

He unbuttoned his shirt as he followed, pushed open the bedroom door and saw Chelsea Cunningham climbing up on some Russian gangster’s luxury small-yacht bed. The previous owner might’ve been a baller who killed guys, dealt guns and drugs and whatever, but there had never been a more beautiful woman on that bed than Chelsea Cunningham.

“You’re so fucking hot,” he said.

“Take off your things,” she said.

He undid his tie, tore it away, took off his shirt, got on the bed on all fours wearing just his chinos and socks and glad he’d been getting to the gym at least twice a week during the winter. Chelsea received him, sitting up now with her knees raised, cupping his neck and kissing his mouth. Her lips were soft and plump; she smelled like strawberries and sativa and leather. He nibbled on her neck and she undid his buckle. They worked together on getting his pants off, his underwear getting caught on his boner, Chelsea tugging on the waistband, freeing his dick and making it dance. She laughed at its performance.

Then she was over top of him and he was lying on his back like her prey. She got between his open legs and kissed at his stomach. She worked her way down, took his penis in her mouth. He wove his fingers through her hair and guided her head up and down as she bobbed on his shaft. Her fingernails went over his scrotum, dipping low, cupping them and squeezing them. She got him moaning and writhing on the bed. Mouth



pulled free, she ran her tongue up from the base to the very tip, got over him on all fours and said, "You want to feel my body?"

He nodded.

"Put your hands on me," she said.

He looked at the flat of her stomach, the tautness of it even as she crouched over him. Perfect breasts hung down, her nipples dark brown and hardened. She moved to put one in his mouth and he sucked on it while rubbing at her sides, feeling the edges of her ribs. He went down her narrow waist, grabbed her ass.

"You like my body, Ben?"

"It's incredible."

"Are you going to fuck me?"

He struggled to answer, and the delay made her look down at him. She took her breast out of his mouth, smiled at him.

He said, "Do we have to?"

"Just want to feel my tits and suck on them? What do I get out of this?"

"I'm sorry."

"What kind of man doesn't want to fuck me?"

"Chelsea, of course I do."

"Ben Todd's got a conscience, huh?"

"I love Libby."

"You're not gonna fuck me?" She gripped his dick. He moaned, made to answer, but she started jerking him furiously, making his knees come up and his stomach tighten.

"You just want a hand job? You just like all those other guys? All that effort to get in my bed and then they shit in it. Rubbery dicks, coming in their shorts before I can take it out, going soft when I look in their eyes, I thought Ben Todd wasn't a big talker..."

"I'm not," he said.

"You're shitting in my bed, Ben," she said and jerked him harder and faster. "Just come in my hand, I'll go home and jerk off with a vibrator..."

"I can't, ah, Chelsea," he said, digging his fingers into his thighs but unable to move away and stop her from stroking him. Her skinny forearms twitched and flexed, the blades of muscle in her slender shoulder rippled and her tits bounced with her effort.

"Just come already. That's all you want, you're just as useless as the other guys. Get your nut off. Nobody can fuck Chelsea right..."

“I can,” he moaned, “I can...”

“Bullshit, Ben, come on your stomach and we can both get out of here...”

And as if she'd actually commanded it, he was suddenly grunting and gasping, spurting all over his chest and stomach while she squeezed and stroked him. They both watched her hand on his erection as his stomach heaved in and out, desperate for breath. She chuckled.

“I'm sorry,” he said.

“It was kinda hot. You're a real squirter, I like that.”

“I'm sorry, Chelsea, I am...”

She drew a long inhale then sighed out slow, turning her hand over back and front and looking at the webs of his semen. He'd splashed it all up his bare body, even onto his neck. She wiped the mess from her fingers onto his hip bone, then she used his tie to dry her hands. She said nothing, and he watched her get up from the bed, walk naked to leave the bedroom, climbing the stairs up to the galley. Her legs were about the sexiest thing he could imagine. He groaned and covered his eyes with his forearm.

Out in the boat's belly he could hear her snatch her clothes off the floor, slide the things back over her bare skin. There were stomps as she beat her bare feet into those expensive boots. The heels clicked on the hardwood floor until they grew faint and then she trotted down the outside steps.

He lay there naked on the bed, semen cold on his stomach, his erection still hard as a rock. Chelsea kicked her starter and her bike bellowed in low grumbles that he felt in the yacht's mattress. He shook his head, forearm hairs scratching his brow.

As her bike rumbled out of the dry dock, he groaned sounds of painful lamentation and he asked the room: “Why didn't I just fuck her?”

FOR FOUR YEARS now Libby worked at a downtown bookstore. She had the primo shift from ten A.M. until six P.M. It didn't used to be that way, in fact when they were first married and they were living out in the west end, it sucked because Lib worked five evenings a week. But the store didn't have a better employee, and it wasn't long before she'd proven that to them. Now she worked days, and it gave them the evenings together. Libby took the subway and then a bus home every night, usually getting home just before seven o'clock. Ben was usually done around five, though sometimes if he had to travel to go and check out a good purchase he might be gone well into the nighttime. But usually it was on him to prepare dinner and today was no exception. In fact, today he'd gone the extra mile.

Libby's favorite was baking at 400° in the oven. His meat lasagna with triple cheese. Lots of ricotta and a half-inch thick crust of mozzarella along the top. He'd made garlic bread and even picked up a good tiramisu from Casa Mia for their dessert.

Did guilt play a factor? One hundred percent.

But now he was at the front door window wringing his hands in a tea towel, looking out the glass insert to see if she was home. Libby was funny in that she eschewed smartphones but had an old flip-phone. She didn't even text. Her sister called her Old School as a nickname, the irony being Georgette was a fuddy-duddy in her own right but couldn't see it.

Now, there, coming down Sarah Ashbridge, a familiar and beloved figure: a cute and shapely five-foot-three foot blonde girl wearing a knee-length skirt, polished flat loafers, a dress shirt, and blazer. She had her

sensible brown leather purse slung over one shoulder in tandem with her work satchel. His heart ached for his precious Lib.

She had a determined quick walk, and he smiled seeing her with her serious face marching along their tree-lined beach side alameda. He unlocked the door, left it open, darted back into the kitchen to check on dinner. There was a smile on his face though his heart was so heavy.

And if he stood still too long, those bad feelings would start to creep up on him. *The awful thing he'd done.* At the party... The awful thing he'd done earlier today when he swore he'd come to his senses.

The biggest fear he had was if he stood still too long and those thoughts got a hold on his mind, it might start to wander and he would find himself considering ludicrous things like what the future might hold. A full-fledged affair. Cheating on his wife. Chelsea falling in love with him. Chelsea leaving her husband. What would the two of them do then? *They could move to a different city, start a new life...*

It was fucking bullshit because he didn't want that. All he wanted was—

Libby's footsteps came into the hall, and she sang out: "I'm ho-ooommme..."

He shouted back: "In the kitchen..."

It was a minute before she showed up, sliding into the kitchen in her slippers, obviously in a good mood. Her face was bright, her eyes wide and happy. She said, "Do I smell... lasagna?..."

"You do," he said, leaned on the kitchen island and she met him over the middle and they kissed.

"Are you serious?"

"Just for you. Triple cheese, the way you like it."

"Oh, my gosh," she said, "this day couldn't get better..."

"You're having a good day?"

"It's been a good day," she said, sliding over a stool so she could sit down and rest her forearms on the island.

"Tell me all about it—wait... Are you wearing lipstick?"

She made a funny, worried sort of face, and her lips tucked inward. He touched his own lips, looked at the pads of his fingers that came away pinkish.

When he looked at her, she still had that troubled brow.

She let her lips pop out and she asked, "Does it look stupid?"

“Stupid? No, no way, Libby. I didn’t mean that all I, just noticed—you don’t usually wear it.”

“Should I take it off?”

“Oh, come on now, baby, don’t be so shy. You look fantastic...”

“Thanks,” she said, but regardless plucked a white paper napkin from atop a square folded pile and dabbed and then puckered her lips on it, cleaning them.

“You’re so silly,” he said, watching her. “Your lipstick looks great.”

“I thought I’d try it out,” she said, folded the napkin over and wiped at her lips again.

He changed the subject. “What was your good news? Why was your day so great?”

“Oh, work was awesome, lots of new deliveries, I fulfilled some rare book orders that got me lots of bookseller credit.”

“You’re good at it.”

“I am,” she said. “And guess what?”

“You got a promotion.”

“No,” she said now, frowning. “Although I should. But, no, it’s not work-related...”

“Then how can I guess?”

She rolled her eyes, understanding how difficult it was what she was asking. She said, “Dorchester is coming this summer to play up in Barrie. Finn is working that show, and he said he can get us tickets, maybe even get us backstage.”

“Wow, that’s awesome,” he said, “that’s your good news?”

“You know how much I love Dorchester.”

“I do, it’s amazing, I can’t wait to go. I didn’t even know they were coming.”

“Me neither, I haven’t seen them since—what was that, Ben? Second year?”

“Yeah, I bet you.”

“Oh, my God, it’s just like we’re back in college...” She hugged herself and ran her fingernails over the backs of her arms, her smile growing wide as she pondered the fun they would have.

He said, “Wait, you were talking to Finn?”

“About the tickets? No. Chelsea came by—”

“Oh, shoot,” he said, “that’s right. She came by this morning?”

Libby asked, "Did she catch up with you?"

He nodded, said, "That was weird," averting his eyes by keeping his hands busy.

"She said she wanted a set or something to shoot a movie?"

"Right. I don't think I have what she was looking for."

"She came by this morning and we had coffee together. She came by to tell me Finn was going to set up that show and he knew I liked Dorchester."

"How did he know that?"

"From at the party. When you were off wherever, we were dancing, we were talking about music and I said how much I like Dorchester."

"This was while you were dancing?"

"No, we were taking a break."

"Right. That's nice of him. He was looking out for you."

"He seems like such a nice guy," she said. "How did he end up with Chelsea?"

"Chelsea has her ways."

"Well, whatever. I'm glad we're all getting along."

"You think Finn's a nice guy?"

"You don't think he's nice?"

"I don't know him. I haven't spent much time with him except at the party."

Libby said, "I didn't either."

"I didn't mean that..."

Libby played with her necklace, pondering how to clarify her point. "It's just, you know, given the way he looks, and he rides a motorcycle..."

"He's got all his tattoos..."

"Right, he's got all those tattoos all over his arms and everything, you might think he was a jerk or he'd be mean or an asshole..."

He laughed. "It's funny hearing you say asshole."

"Don't make fun of me," she kidded, clucking her tongue and smiling. "I'm right..."

"You are. He looks like the kind of guy who might be an asshole."

"I think he has a good energy."

"I'm glad you two are getting along."

She frowned and showed him worried eyes. "Ben, what do you *mean*—getting along?"

“Nothing,” he said, wondering what he was getting at. Why was he throwing shade in her face? It was him who was the asshole. He didn’t even ride a motorcycle or have tattoos, yet he was clearly the one who was an asshole. Chelsea had given him a blow job, jerked him off today, and here he’s acting like Libby’s the one who’s up to no good. He slid over to the oven, saying, “You ready for dinner?”

She clasped her hands and leaned across the counter again, pouting her lips. He slid close and kissed her. She said, “I’m so excited.”

“What do you want to do tonight?” he asked scissoring the oven door open and donning his oven mitts.

“I want to eat lasagna until my stomach bursts and I want to watch TV.”

“You don’t want to walk down the boardwalk?”

“Oh,” she said, “that’s awesome. That *is*—*that’s* what I want to do...”

“Then maybe we’ll go to bed after a little TV because I have to get an early start tomorrow.” He slid out the lasagna, put it on the counter so Libby could admire it then retrieved the baguettes he’d turned into garlic bread from the warming tray.

Libby beamed at her awesome husband. “Look at you, Ben.”

He presented dinner with his oven mitts, gesturing over his fine spread. “What do you think? You want to go crazy, have a glass of wine?”

“One glass of wine,” she said, smiling at him warmly and they met over top of his steaming lasagna for another kiss.

AFTER DINNER, Ben took care of the dishes while Libby went upstairs to change into comfortable beach-walking clothes. He got the dishwasher loaded and put the leftovers away in Tupperware, putting aside a serving for his wife's lunch tomorrow.

Libby was back down in fifteen minutes wearing shorts and a polo shirt and her comfy walking-around sneakers. She hopped off the last step and it somehow hurt him more to see her in such a good mood. It heightened the scale between her happiness and his badness—it would be a big drop off for her to go to obliviously gleeful to the black reality he'd created for them today.

Happy smile pushed on his face, he grabbed the house keys, took her arm and led her out to the stoop and locked up. They strolled their street, waving to Carol and Gwendolyn as they passed their well-kept home, the two women sitting together on their porch and sipping iced tea. They went down the Main Street past the burger place and its awesome smell of grilling meat, made their way to the tennis courts and watched an energetic foursome for a while.

It was a warm summer evening, the beach busy with bicycles skateboards and rollerblades; there were even people brave enough to get in the water. They strolled the boardwalk as far as the yacht club, turned around and headed back. Libby asked him if he bought his boat today and his stomach turned over.

"I did," he told her, "I'm having it put back in the water next week."

"Aren't you going to ship it?"

"It's pretty big, and you know, it's a *boat*, Libby..."



“Oh, shoot,” she laughed, “that’s right...”

“I’m going to pay a sailor, I don’t know, five-to-ten grand to sail it out to Africa.”

“You’re so cool,” she said.

“Am I? It’s not me sailing across the ocean, you know. I just made a phone call...”

“You’re still pretty cool,” she said, and looped her forearm under his and hugged herself to him as they strolled.

THEY DECIDED they would watch the whole last season of Game of Thrones over again and were two episodes in when Chelsea sent her first text.

**Chelsea:** You kicking yourself for not fucking me?

He jolted, enough that it startled Libby who'd curled up in the crook of his arm, the two of them on the couch together, the AC off and the windows open, a cool breeze keeping their family room comfortable.

Libby asked, "What is it?"

"About the boat," he said.

Libby sat away from him, her arms folded, eyes sleepy. "Problems?"

"Maybe..." He looked from his phone screen back to the TV.

Libby asked, "You want me to pause it?"

"No, no, we'll keep watching..." With one thumb, he texted back.

**Ben:** maybe

It was a few more minutes before Chelsea got back to him.

**Chelsea:** I bet you're burning up inside

He texted back.

**Ben:** I made the right decision

**Chelsea:** good boy Ben

**Ben:** I'm sorry

**Chelsea:** wow, you really think your god's gift

**Ben:** No

**Chelsea:** apologizing because you didn't fuck me

**Ben:** I wanted to

**Chelsea:** Ben Todd just ended up being another high school loser laying on his back with come on his stomach

He sighed and grumbled and Libby turned her face to his profile. He said to her, "Hey, maybe pause it."

Worry pulled on her brow. "Really? Is the sale going to go through?"

"It's done, baby," he reassured her. "This is just logistics now, can you give me a minute?..."

She nodded rapidly because she was kind and a team player. She blinked her big brown eyes behind her clear frame glasses. Now she asked him: "Do you need anything?"

"Need anything?" He stood, rubbing at his brow.

"You look so stressed."

"I'm fine," he said, "just you know..."

"Hey," she said, "my dad left some of that whiskey—you know, it's a single malt or whatever. Can I get you a glass of that?"

"Yeah, you know what, that would be really sweet."

"Okay, go to your office and deal with your boat. Meet me back here in..."

He stood there dumbly then realized she was waiting for an approximation.

“Fifteen, Lib, just give me fifteen minutes.”

She gave him a tight-lipped curt nod. “I’m going to make popcorn and pour my man a whiskey.”

He stopped her before she darted away. “Can I have a Coke, too?”

“You got it. Go on and deal with your boat,” she said, got up as well and the two of them left the family room in opposite directions, him going up to his study, Libby going into the kitchen.

HE CLOSED himself in his office, sat in his leather swivel chair and swung around so he could look out over the black treetops of the neighborhood, the sky a deep inky blue. He texted.

**Ben:** I'm not a high school loser

It took a minute for Chelsea to get back to him.

**Chelsea:** you just talk a big game

**Ben:** I do not talk a big game

**Chelsea:** walking around like you got big balls Ben. Go to buy that boat for a mil

**Ben:** it's more than a million

**Chelsea:** Mr. show off all talk no go

**Ben:** what do you want from me?

**Chelsea:** I don't want anything from you

**Ben:** then what are you texting me for?

**Chelsea:** I wanted to show you something

**Ben:** what is it?

Now he watched three dots dancing while he waited for her text to come back. Only instead of words, an image flashed up, and it was clear what the picture was but he touched it anyway to make it bigger. Chelsea's graceful hand, her two fingers spread in an upside down peace sign, the pads spreading apart her glistening pink petals. Chelsea Cunningham just sent him a picture of her pussy

"Holy shit," he sighed and grabbed at his stomach. This girl wanted it so bad. She couldn't leave him alone.

He responded.

**Ben:** hot

**Chelsea:** hot? That's my pussy you piece of shit

**Ben:** why are you so angry?

**Chelsea:** You left me so high and dry today Ben. Just like all those other guys always talking about how they're going to smash my pussy with their rock-hard giant dicks and yet no one ever comes through. Am I so intimidating?

**Ben:** you are intimidating

**Chelsea:** I had to come home and masturbate you asshole

"Jesus," he said, his hand forming a fist over his stomach and pushing inward.

**Ben:** Did you?

**Chelsea:** I'm still so hot Ben. That picture is fresh I got home after the boat and I had to bust out one of my dildos you had me fucking plastic when I should have the real thing

**Ben:** I told you I was sorry I just can't

**Chelsea:** you're garbage man

**Ben:** Fuck you Chelsea

**Chelsea:** I bet as soon as you put it in me it would've gone soft

**Ben:** I would not

**Chelsea:** at least you didn't come in your pants before I even took it out

**Ben:** I would have fucked you all afternoon in that boat

**Chelsea:** big talk Ben

**Ben:** I would have

**Chelsea:** I'm sure you would have I'm sure we would have done it 10 times I would've come 20

**Ben:** you would have

**Chelsea:** I guess we'll never know

**Ben:** I guess we'll never know

**Chelsea:** Finn is away on Saturday night

**Ben:** good for him

**Chelsea:** I'm going to be home all alone

**Ben:** don't you have that dildo?

**Chelsea:** you're such a chicken shit

**Ben:** no I'm not

**Chelsea:** garbage Ben

**Ben:** I'm not garbage

**Chelsea:** whatever. I can guarantee you if you can squeeze that big ego out of your house walk over one street I will give you the fuck of a lifetime

**Ben:** I'm sure you would

**Chelsea:** you ever been fucked so good you black out?

**Ben:** Sure

**Chelsea:** bull shit I can't see Libby licking your asshole she won't even suck your dick for you

"Holy Jesus," he sighed at her awful words.

**Ben:** That's gross

**Chelsea:** right gross my tongue in your asshole tell me it's gross



**Ben:** you're savage

**Chelsea:** 7 o'clock on Saturday Ben I'll even cook you dinner

**Ben:** I can't

**Chelsea:** fuck you Ben good night

"Shit, shit, shit," he sighed, his arms heavy, chin going up so he could stare at his idle ceiling fan. He felt exhausted, like he'd just run a marathon. His cock throbbed in his pants, his heart pounded in his chest. He eased the chair sideways, leaned over to twist his office lock then did down his fly and pulled his dick out. He opened the messenger window again, clicked the picture of Chelsea's fingered-open pussy. It was a beautiful one, a perfect one. Smoothly shaved—he'd felt it today, put his fingers inside it!—the petals were smooth and bright pink, her interior deeper in color and he knew the heat he'd felt and he ached to be inside it.

No lube necessary, he jerked himself with the slippery excitement that the texted image brought him. He looked at that model pussy, the one he dreamed about when he was in high school, and stroked himself hard and fast. His eyes went narrow, and he wondered if Chelsea *would* lick his asshole—was that something she did? What would sex be like with her?—he'd never been with a girl like that; not just beautiful but so sexually confident. His heart rate was all aflutter now, and he ejaculated in his hand while staring at another woman's pussy. The experience left him panting and folded over in his chair.

He cleaned himself with tissue, closed up his phone and changed his password. Libby was not a snoop but she would be devastated if she found her way inside his phone.

"Oh, my God," he sighed.

*Why didn't he just fuck her today?* It would've been done...

And then what? Run off with her?—"So fucking stupid, Ben," he muttered, chastising himself. He slumped back in his chair, did up his fly with his penis tucked back in his underwear. He plucked new tissue, wiped at his brow and his upper lip.

When he was ready, he went downstairs to join his wonderful wife so they could binge Game of Thrones together.

AT BEDTIME, Libby changed into a T-shirt and cotton pajama shorts and met him in bed. He lay with his head propped up on the pillow, looking at a picture of the yacht he'd bought today. He wanted to be looking at that glistening pink Chelsea-mouth but was content to just watch pictures of the master stateroom and the bed where he'd almost fucked Chelsea Cunningham.

Libby came to bed on her knees, pulled the sheet over herself and tumbled with her back bumping up against him. She said, "Everything still good?"

"Yep, I think so," he said, "I think I've fixed everything."

"That's a relief," she said, "you feel good enough you could rub my back again?"

"Sure thing, sweetheart," he said, shut down his phone and tossed it to the night table. Libby stayed on her side and he rubbed the center of her back with one hand, his thumb drawing circles over her shoulder blade. Her eyes were open as she looked across the room, her lashes blinking.

She said, "You remember when we saw Dorchester in second year?"

"I remember."

"Remember we went out with the gang that night and we had dinner at that Chinese restaurant like right in deep Chinatown?"

"I remember. It was a great night."

"Remember there was that Fuk Ken Fried Rice, and you guys ordered it, you and Steeple and Price?"

"How could we not, it was called Fuckin' Fried Rice..."

She giggled. “When it came, it looked like a big octopus had eaten a smaller octopus and then vomited it up on a plate of rice.”

It got him laughing too. “It was *really* gross...”

“You guys ate it.”

“Maybe that’s why I don’t like Dorchester.”

“Hey—you don’t like Dorchester?...” She glanced over her shoulder.

“I like Dorchester just fine,” he said, “just not as much as you.”

“You remember how sick you were that night?”

“I was an idiot.”

“You were twenty. It was your birthday weekend, remember?”

“No excuse. I bet that Chinese restaurant was just fucking with the white people.”

“Like they get so many dumb white people ordering Fun Ken Fried Rice because it’s funny, like they made the name up and then just throw garbage on some rice for some laughs of their own...?”

“I can still taste it,” he mumbled, digging his thumbs along the knobs of her spine.

She whispered, “Hey, Ben...?”

“What?”

Her bare foot sole pressed the front of his shin. “You feel like getting frisky?”

His thumb stilled on her back. “I do,” he said quietly.

“Do you want to?” Her voice was breathy and hopeful.

“I do.”

Libby wiggled herself closer, pushing with her knees and feet until she was pressed right against him. He moved his hand from her back to caress her hip. “Roll over,” he said.

“Can we do it like this?”

“Do it like what?”

Then even quieter: “Can we do it like spoons?”

He suppressed a giggle from the surprise at Libby’s bushy-tailed request. “You want that?”

She nodded.

“You’re so cute,” he said.

He turned so his chest was against her back, ran his hand from her waist to cup her smooth tummy... And now he couldn’t help comparing his wife to Chelsea Cunningham. Chelsea Cunningham was tall and lean. His wife

was petite and soft. Libby's breasts were probably a little bigger, her tummy a little rounder, her navel a little deeper. Chelsea had a hard body. A sexy body. Now his cock was hard and pressing against Libby's bottom. Libby began to squirm a little under his touch as he slipped his fingers into her panties. He ran his fingers down his wife's pubic hair, felt it scratch between his fingers, found her center stripe warm and wet and inviting. He slipped his fingers inside her. Libby was tighter than Chelsea. Maybe that was his imagination. Chelsea had been with a lot of guys and Libby had only been with one.

Now he couldn't wait any longer and he withdrew his hand from her panties to push down at his pajama pants. Libby worked her cotton shorts down to her knees, and he stroked at her opening with his tip.

"Why do you want to do it like this?" he whispered. It wasn't their first time, but it was unusual.

"Is it okay?"

"Better than okay."

"Is it weird?"

"You're amazing," he told her, then pushed himself inside her. Her interior was hot on him, and he sunk himself deep. She let out a thin high warbling sound as he started to pulse himself in and out of her. She made soft quiet gasps. He was sure that Chelsea was a screamer. He was sure Chelsea would thrash in their bed, probably claw at his back as he fucked her. *Why didn't he just fuck her?* She wanted it. The hottest girl in his high school. The hottest girl he could ever get—even now she was insanely beautiful. *Why didn't he just do it?*

"You're so tight," he whispered.

"Ben," she scolded him because she wasn't a fan of dirty talk.

"You feel so good," he amended.

His hand slipped underneath her T-shirt and between her breasts. He cupped one in his hand and rubbed her hard nipple with the pad of his thumb. Now he pictured himself this way in that multi-million-dollar boat, laying with Chelsea Cunningham, fucking her. *Imagine the sounds she would make. The dirty things she would do.* Spooning was nothing to her. She would ride him. He knew it, he was sure of it. She would get on top and pound on him like a jackhammer until they broke that Russian gangster's bed. He'd have to pay to replace it before he shipped the yacht to Saudi Arabia. His semen would have to be cleaned off the ceiling and the

windows. He could have fucked her all day. He could've done it ten times before he got home to make lasagna. Shown Chelsea what Ben Todd was made of. Show her all those fantasies he'd had laying in bed when he was in high school were not just wishes—he could make them reality. He would spread her out on that bed and pound her until she screamed his name—

“Oh, fuck, shit,” he said, bubbling over and ejaculating inside his wife with barely a warning.

Libby whispered, “Did you...?”

“Sorry,” he said, “sorry...”

“That’s okay, Ben,” she said, and smoothed his hand over top of her cotton T-shirt.

“Sorry, I don’t know how that happened...”

“It’s a compliment,” she sighed.

“You want to give me a minute?”

“It’s okay,” she said softly.

“Sorry,” he said, feeling himself shrink inside her.

“It’s okay, Ben, it’s really okay...”

It was for the better because this guilty feeling that was washing over him right now would extinguish anymore passionate lovemaking tonight. He’d just made love with his beautiful wife who he cherished since they were kids—but he’d done it thinking of another woman. That mean high school bitch who’d been unkind to his wife when they were young. He betrayed her in more ways than one, and his heart was hurting for her.

She asked if he wanted a towel and he said he did. Libby sat up, cupping her hand between her legs and dancing on tiptoe over to the dresser where she withdrew a clean towel. She dabbed at herself, hiding away so he wouldn’t see. He looked up at the ceiling to give her space. She returned, put the towel under the sheet for him and recovered so he could clean without exposing himself.

PART 3  
SUCCOTASH  
SATURDAY, JUNE 29

AT SEVEN O'CLOCK on the nose, he showed up at Chelsea's door with a hundred-dollar bottle of red wine. As soon as he pressed the doorbell, he'd already taken a step back looking to get the hell out of here. What was he thinking? *This was crazy...*

But then there was movement behind the glass and he knew it was too late. He straightened his posture and waited. The door opened and there she was: Chelsea Cunningham.

The girl of his dreams wore a turquoise tank top that clung to the perfect shape of her breasts then billowed loosely around her tummy. She wore jeans again, faded Levi's that looked soft as felt. Her feet were bare, a gold ring on the toe next to the pinky on her right foot. Her hair was messy, hanging around her beautiful face and spilling over her tanned shoulders. "Well, *holy shit*," she said.

"How's it going?" he asked, trying to sound cool.

"Ben fucking Todd. What the hell are *you* doing here?"

He showed her the bottle of wine and an open palm. "I thought you invited me for dinner."

Now she folded her arms and leaned against the doorjamb, put one bare foot over top of the other and studied him, her eyes going up and down while she smiled. "I did, Ben, I did. But there was no way in hell I thought you would ever show up."

"Because I'm garbage?"

Her smile was warm and nice. "Because you're a big sack of chicken-shit garbage."

"And yet I'm here," he said.



“I couldn’t be happier,” she said, that smile pulling to one side, practically sneering. “Come on in, let’s have some dinner.”

He handed her the bottle of wine (but she didn’t even read the label), stepped up into her foyer, and she closed the door behind him. Bottle cradled at her side, she said, “Come into the kitchen...”

“Wow, your place is awesome,” he said.

“We didn’t just move in,” she told him, “we’ve been here a while.”

The narrow foyer was furnished with vintage items and potted plants. Everything was black and white, the floors were polished ebony wood, and original art in contrasting frames leaned artfully on shelves and even on the floor. The art shouted colors, bright primary pieces, some invoking comic books and old lurid movies from the fifties and sixties.

He kicked off his shoes, put his hands in his pockets and strolled along behind her as they headed toward the archway that led to the kitchen. He could smell that she was cooking. There was garlic and meat and...

But when he came into the kitchen, he found they weren’t alone. Standing at the counter with her back to them was a tall slender girl with a body not that different from Chelsea’s. This girl had long jet-black hair that hung down to her ass. She wore cut off jean shorts and her legs were dark and shapely. There were feathers and arrows tattooed from her knee down one calf toward her ankle. She also wore a tank top, a white one; tattoos scrawled down her right arm. “Oh,” he said, “I didn’t know—”

“That I had company?”

The girl turned now and smiled at him, doing that up-and-down eye thing. She said, “Oh, hey, he’s cute.”

“Ben, this is Neve, Neve this is Ben.”

“She told me all about you,” the girl said, turning back to stir her pot, back arched gracefully to keep her face free of steam.

“Sorry,” Ben said, “if I knew you were having company I wouldn’t have intruded.”

“*Intrude*, Ben? Don’t be crazy. Come on have dinner with us. I didn’t think you were going to show up, so I invited a friend over.”

Neve turned over her shoulder again. “She said you wouldn’t show up.”

“I’m here,” he said nervously.

“Ben brought wine,” Chelsea said now, and sidled up to her tall tanned friend. The girls looked at the wine, and Chelsea opened the drawer and withdrew a wing-handled corkscrew.

He said, "Want me to get it?"

Chelsea said to Neve, "So chivalrous. Such a gentleman..."

"Can you open this bottle of wine for us, Ben?" Neve said, "We don't know how this thingy works," and she took the winged handles of the opener and flapped them up and down.

"I'm just trying to be helpful," he said. The girls laughed. "You guys are making dinner, I have to do *something*."

"You can open the wine," Neve said, facing him now with her hand flopped over, presenting him the bottle opener. Chelsea extended toward him the bottle of wine, neck first.

"Thank you," he said, accepting the gifts, "what are you guys making?"

"Neve's making succotash."

Neve added: "With lots of bacon..."

"Sounds awesome," he said.

Neve ran her tongue over her top lip, studied him, folding her arms. She was beautiful, Native, smoky brown eyes that looked in him too deep. Across her chest was an iconic eagle shape, a bright primary tattoo, one in the Northwest Coast style. On her shoulder, a realistic wolf in feather headdress, a beautiful woman's face under its muzzle. She wore long dangling earrings, and a beaded choker. "How's that bottle of wine coming?"

"It's good," he said, "it's in good hands." He set the bottle down and ran the corkscrew through the top. "Where's Finn?"

Neve laughed then returned to stirring her pot. Chelsea said, "He's away. I told you that."

"Away where?" he asked, scissoring down the corkscrew's arms and pulling out the cork with a pop. "Glasses?"

Chelsea opened a cupboard and brought down three spotless wineglasses. "Finn's setting up a show for Cooter out in Peterborough."

"I thought he worked at the Sony."

"He does. He's full time there, their engineer. But he also consults. They let him. He'll do shows wherever, as long as the band's big enough, or the paycheck."

"Libby said Finn can get tickets for Dorchester."

"Libby excited?"

"She is."

"And how is Libby? Where is *she* tonight?"

“At home,” he said.

“You told her you had to go out for work?”

“I have things to do,” he said stiffly, eyes shifting from Chelsea to Neve’s back, the girl still stirring dinner.

Chelsea frowned at him, said, “Don’t worry, Ben, Neve’s cool. She’s not going to rat you out.”

“Rat me out for what?” he said a little coarsely, defiant against his own infidelity.

Chelsea leaned back to see Neve’s face, said, “Ben married his high school sweetheart.”

Neve cooed sweetly, leaned back swishing her hair aside and smiling at him. “How cute,” she said.

“We’ve been together a long time,” he said, sounding sullen.

With Neve still facing away, he stepped back toward the archway between the kitchen and the hall. Chelsea eased herself off the counter and sauntered toward him. Quietly, so only she could hear, he said, “Maybe I should go. You have company. It’s best if I probably go home...”

Chelsea smiled and licked her lower lip. She moved slowly to get very close to him. Her lips practically touched his ear as she whispered, “Chicken-shits go home...”

THEY ATE the succotash on the back patio. The sky faded from bright to hazy orange above them, deepening to a denim blue. They drank the bottle of wine he'd brought, and Chelsea opened another of her own. When the sun was just about down, Neve said they should go back inside. They gathered around a low ebony coffee table set between two leather loveseats. Chelsea plopped herself on the loveseat, and Neve sat cross-legged on the floor with her back against it.

Arranged on the table were decorative items: a vase, a hard-bound book on The Who, a brass urn, dried flowers, and an ashtray. There was also a steel cylinder, a lighter, and a leather pouch, these items arranged together at the corner. Neve dragged them in front of her, opened the satchel and withdrew a small wooden pipe. From the steel cylinder she tapped ground weed into the pipe's bowl and used the lighter to smoke it. She passed the pipe to Chelsea who also took a long draw. Chelsea offered it to him but he said no.

Neve exhaled tumbling blue smoke and batted it away with her hand. She said, "You don't smoke?"

He shook his head no.

"We don't have to. Does it bother you?" He said it didn't, and Neve said, "You sure you don't want to try? It's a nice sativa, make you feel good, not tired."

"I'm okay."

Chelsea laughed an exhaling cloud of smoke, said, "Ben's a square."

"I'm not a square," he said.

Neve said, "You're so mean, Chelsea. Ben's not a square."

Chelsea said, "No, not now. He *was* pretty buttoned-up in high school..."

"That was high school," he said. "Things are different now."

"Tell me about it," Chelsea said.

Ben said, "It's getting late, anyway."

Chelsea put both arms over the back of the loveseat and crossed one leg over the other. She bounced her bare foot up and down. She said, "Goody-two-shoes."

"I'm not."

"Not you."

"Who?"

To Neve, Chelsea said, "You know Ben's never got a blow job from his wife?"

"Hey..."

Neve looked to Chelsea, her face a calm expression of disappointment. She turned to face Ben, said, "That's too bad, Ben. Really?"

"That's my business. Chelsea shouldn't be saying that..."

"Relax, Ben. I thought you were cool..."

"I'm cool," he said.

Chelsea said, "I only know that because I gave Ben a blow job last week."

"Hey," he said again, "seriously..."

Neve laughed, and Chelsea said, "See, he's not in high school anymore. Ben's in the big leagues."

"High school was a long time ago."

"It was, Ben. You're a grown ass man now."

"I am, and I should probably be going home now." He slapped hands on his knees.

"You're gonna miss out on all the fun."

"What fun? The fun where you poke at me?"

"Ben wants to know what's fun," Chelsea said, looking down to Neve now who looked up over her shoulder at her friend.

Neve turned to him and said, "We're not making fun of you, Ben. You're nice."

"Everybody says I'm nice," he murmured.

Chelsea said, "Ben's not so nice. Deep down, Ben is a bad boy..."

"That's not true."

Chelsea said, "It's plenty true. I tell you what, Ben..." She eased forward so her butt pushed down the front lip of the couch, elbows resting on her knees. "You can go if you want. You'll have to imagine what you're going to miss out on. You'll never know..."

"It's late..."

Chelsea didn't respond, now slinking off the couch to sit on the floor next to Neve. They were shoulder to shoulder looking at each other very close. Slowly their faces came together and his heart began to race. Their lips parted and their mouths touched. Chelsea put a hand up to caress Neve's neck and their lips began to work together, the two of them deeply kissing. When their cheeks hollowed, he knew they were sucking on each other's tongues. He watched as both of their tank tops slowly showed the pushed-out buds of their aroused nipples. His stomach began to ache, his testicles getting cinched up in his tightening scrotum. He watched intently as they made out. When their mouths came apart, they looked deeply in each other's eyes, Chelsea still caressing her friend's slender neck, Neve's beaded choker making a soft clicking with the strokes of her long graceful thumb. Neve whispered to Chelsea: "I think he's still here."

"I think he's still here, too," she said. They made a slow production of turning their faces toward him, pressing their cheeks together. They smiled wide enough he was sure they were on the verge of bursting out laughing at him.

He said, "I can tell you two are in drama together."

They both giggled.

Neve said, "Why don't you come over. You just going to sit there and watch?"

Chelsea said, "Pervert."

"I'll come over," he said, standing up now and adjusting his pants. His erection humped out his fly, the knot of his cock head pushing out at the side. They were both looking between his legs and he covered up as he crossed over to their side of the coffee table. "What do you want me to do?"

Chelsea sighed, asked, "Are you going to need instructions all night long?"

"No..."

Neve said, "You can start by taking your pants off."

"Here, if we wait for him, it will take all night," Chelsea said reaching overhead now and beginning to undo his buckle. While she undid his pants,

Neve kissed Chelsea's shoulder but kept her eyes on his. When the pants were finally unzipped and Chelsea began tugging them down with his underwear, his erection bounced when it was freed.

Neve said, "You don't get a blow job at home, why don't you sit on the couch and let me try..."

"Okay," he said, unbuttoning three buttons on his shirt then just pulling it over his head and tossing it to the chair where he'd been sitting. "Aren't you guys going to get naked?"

Neve repeated his phrase in a mocking sort of tone, "Aren't you guys going to get naked?... Then giggled and kissed his knee. His balls rolled over in their sack.

"Told you he was a pervert," Chelsea said. They both laughed again.

"You want to undress us?" Neve slipped onto the couch on her knees and came close to him. She smelled like spicy cooking and flowers. Her skin was warm, the closeness of her neck made his eyes flutter. He ached to suckle on that graceful spot where her tendons swooped into her collarbone. "You want to kiss me, don't you?"

He nodded. Neve caressed his neck and face, lowered her lips to his. They were soft and warm and wet, so different in small ways from Chelsea's and his Libby's, too. He touched her arm and a jolt of electricity went through him. Her skin was hot, her muscle close to the skin. Then he gasped into Neve's kiss as Chelsea's mouth slipped over his erection.

Chelsea sat on the other side of him, leaned over with her head in his lap. She bobbed up and down while he made out with some girl he just met tonight called Neve—it was wilder than he'd ever anticipated a sexual escapade in his life could ever be. His pulse was fast and erratic, and his breaths came quick.

Neve raised up higher than him, and he looked up at her aching, wanting to have his lips over hers again. She took one of his hands and encouraged him to get up on one knee, his other foot still on the hardwood floor. She kissed his chest, he ran his hands through her hair. Chelsea kissed his hipbone, working her way around to kiss at the small of his back.

"Oh, wow," he moaned, the pleasure becoming overwhelming.

Chelsea slipped down, putting her heels on the floor, squatting with her lower back against the curled seat of the couch. Neve's kisses worked down to his stomach. Both of them ran their tongues and their mouths over his skin and he put one hand over his heart feeling its patter under his palm,

looking to the front and back as two beautiful women pleased him with their mouths. Chelsea grabbed his ass cheek, and it made him cry out softly. She lifted it, kissed her way across it...

“Oh, shoot,” he moaned. *She wasn't joking...*

Neve kissed her way lower, her graceful hand encircling the base of his erection, gripping it tight with thumb and one finger and sinking him into her mouth. He cried out again, arching his back, grabbing a handful of leather at the back of the couch to support himself. Chelsea wiggled her tongue all through his undercarriage, poking and prodding at his anus, licking at the backside of his scrotum. His testicles had climbed up inside his body, and Neve bobbed up and down his shaft.

The two girls made moaning sounds, bombinating in their throats, breathing heavily through their noses. His stomach had tightened as hard as suspension cable and he worried that he was going to black out. Chelsea wasn't kidding about this kind of sex. He'd never had an experience like this—and thought he never would...

Now Chelsea's kisses worked their way around to his hipbone again, and Neve pushed him back to sit on the couch. Chelsea spread his knees wider and the two girls got between his thighs. They worked his cock in unison. Taking turns. One girl would suck on his cock the other would suck on his balls. They used their hands, Chelsea stuck her index finger in his anus. They pleased him with purpose. They wanted him to enjoy this. They looked in his eyes while they performed the dirtiest actions he could imagine. They passed his cock back and forth like they shared a popsicle, knowing their performance would please a man...

“Wait,” he said, “I'm, mm, yeah, I'm going to come...”

Both of them nodded, encouraging him, hands and tongues moving faster, eyes turned to his cock so they could see him erupt...

When he finally ejaculated, it was in Neve's mouth. Chelsea was gripping him hard, three fingers squeezing his balls, an 'O.K.' sign locked around the base. He flexed his stomach over and over again as the content of his testicles squirted into Neve's closed mouth. She locked his eyes with hers, completely unabashed and confident while she took his load into her waiting mouth.

When he was done, Chelsea flicked his penis out of Neve's mouth and jerked him fast. Neve kept her lips pursed closed. Chelsea stroked him hard enough it made him jump and squirm on the chair. Chelsea laughed, Neve



did too, cupping her hand under her mouth and hunching her shoulders. He realized she still kept his seed in the cup of her tongue. She held up a finger indicating for them to wait.

Chelsea said, “You’re not going to laugh and spray that all over us, are you?”

Neve waved her hands back and forth, her eyes squinting closed like she would laugh.

“Come here,” Chelsea said, gripping the back of Neve’s neck, pulling her in for a kiss. The two of them made out, their wet mouths slurping over each other’s, his semen spilling over their lips, over their chins and down their necks. They traded his fluids back and forth until there was nothing left, and he just watched their tongues writhe against each other.

When they were done, they both laughed and pulled hair away from their faces. Chelsea looked at him and said, “All that big talk about going all night—you got more in you?”

He nodded. “I do.”

FINN AND CHELSEA'S bedroom was a small space just like his own, their bed a king-size fourposter. The girls brought him upstairs, him naked, them still dressed. When he climbed on the bed one of them spanked his ass.

Now he was sitting up in the pillows, looking in the dim light as two slender beautiful shapes came up the bed on either side, getting on their knees. He watched as they kissed again, both of them using their hands to slowly undress each other. All he could hear was the loud wet sounds of their mouths, the dry sounds of their fabric sliding against their smooth dry skin.

When they were naked, he got up to join them. All three of them on their knees, he interjected with his own mouth. They accepted him, kissing him, caressing him, kissing each other, caressing each other. Everyone's hands explored each other's bodies. They squeezed at his balls, stroked his cock, he cupped their ass cheeks, slid fingers into their nether regions, feeling both of them were hot and wet. He dipped low and took one of Neve's nipples into his mouth. She ran her fingernails through his hair.

Soon all three of them were laying flat on the bed together, arms and legs intertwining, mouths working over each other.

Sometimes when he had a nipple in his mouth, he was unsure whether it was Neve's or Chelsea's. When someone stroked his cock, he didn't know whose hand it was.

Neve got behind him, and he was face-to-face with Chelsea, the two of them looking into each other's eyes, touching each other's faces and kissing. Neve scratched his back and Chelsea rolled over and opened her

legs. Neve nudged him, encouraging him to get over top of Chelsea. He did, then lowered between her legs. Neve squeezed his balls, gripped his cock and pointed it downward. He lowered and Neve guided his bare and unprotected cock inside Chelsea. The girl of his dreams with her legs open and accepting his erection inside her. It was unreal. It couldn't possibly be real...

He slid all the way inside, deep as he could, she circled her arms around his neck and locked her mouth on his. He rolled his hips against hers, and Neve massaged his shoulders and back while he fucked her. She was lean and hard under him, her body squirming against his, her pussy gripping on him. She grabbed his ass cheeks, encouraged him to fuck her harder and faster.

He did, he fucked her hard and kept the pace. At some point Neve moved down toward the foot of the bed and knowing she watched his cock going in and out of Chelsea drove him wild. She encouraged him by spanking his ball sack while he pounded. His breaths came quick and erratic.

Chelsea whispered, "Come inside me, Ben..."

It was impossible for him to hold out. The feel, the wildness, her dirty words, Neve's playful spying and caressing. He exploded inside her. His whole body seized and as his orgasm ripped through him, tore him up like a passing tornado of broken glass, his juvenile mind imagined how his buddies would die when he told them about this before class on Monday.

He'd just had sex with Chelsea Cunningham. Without a condom. She didn't even ask him for one. He came inside her body. As his breath chugged and his mind struggled to make sense of the libertine badness that had somehow slithered his way, he felt her nails caress his back and he chuckled and groaned.

"Unbelievable," he sighed.

Chelsea purred under him, flexed her pussy's grip on his cock, milking him.

It hadn't been long, not even a quarter of an hour, maybe twenty minutes, but he couldn't hold out longer than that. A disappointment worked through him. Chelsea hadn't squawked or screamed or even dug her nails deep into him. He hadn't impressed her. But he wasn't done yet, he knew he could go all night...

IT DIDN'T TAKE LONG for the two girls to get his cock hard as steel again. Neve made out with him, both of them on their sides. Chelsea sucked his cock till it was fully hard, then she guided her friend to turn the other way. Neve gave him her back, and he caressed her small breasts while she raised a knee. Now it was Chelsea taking his cock and guiding it into Neve. They were doing it like spoons, the way his wife had asked him the other night. Only, with Libby the request had been out of left field and outrageous. Ben and Libby didn't do it like spoons, they did it from the textbook, man on woman, missionary style. But spoon-style with these two was fluff. Spoons was sweet and innocent compared to the sexual depravity he knew they were capable of. Both of them level ten sex beasts who had sucked his cock in tandem, tongued his anus, snowballed his semen. It was like he was scrolling the channels on Pornhub, only he was in every sex scene.

But for some reason, putting his dick inside Neve from behind on their sides like this had him thinking of Libby, and it was wrenching his heart. He grew uncomfortable and tried to shift positions. Chelsea guided Neve now to roll with him, Ben going to his back and the Native girl on top of him, her back against his chest. She was light as a feather but it didn't stop his breaths from constricting having her weight on him. Her long black hair tangled in his mouth and around his nose. She giggled as she struggled to balance, and he cupped his hands over her breasts. His cock slipped out of her. Neve got her heels down and Chelsea grabbed his dick and jerked it. When Neve was stabilized, Chelsea guided his cock inside Neve again.

Chelsea put her face where they were connected and ate her friend out. Sometimes she would take both his balls in her mouth.

As he got closer to another orgasm, Chelsea flicked his cock out of Neve and used her hand again, getting him squirming and grunting in Neve's ear, his hands working in circles over her hardened nipples. Then she was guiding his cock into Neve's back hole and the night got even darker.

Neve made soft squeaks and grunts accepting him, but once he was in, and her rectum was slicked with their excitement, Neve liked it, and hummed appreciatively as he fucked her ass. Then Chelsea was overtop both of them, taking Neve's mouth with a kiss.

The two girls made out passionately while he pushed in and out of Neve's tight backside, and soon he was ready to go off again.

Chelsea broke their kiss for a moment so she could whisper, "Come in her ass, Ben." Neve giggled.

In three more strokes from that instruction he was ejaculating, driving himself deep into Neve and lifting her up, riding on his body.

When he was dry, he panted with exhaustion, and the two girls laughed and patted his arm. Chelsea helped Neve off, and she rolled onto her tummy, her ass stuck up in the air.

Chelsea said to him: "Ben, go in my nightstand drawer..."

He got up on his elbows and watched as Chelsea spread Neve's cheeks apart, the girl twisting at the hips, so she could watch over her shoulder. Her ass was smooth and shapely, and Chelsea spread her wide enough even in the low light he could see the aperture of her anus. It flexed in and out, and right before his eyes it began to spill over with a pearly sludge. Chelsea put her mouth over it.

"Fuck me," he sighed, backing toward the edge of the bed. He chanced a glance over to the drawer as he opened it and saw what Chelsea must be requesting: a large penis-shaped dildo. The insertable end wasn't much larger than him, the base bulging out to accommodate a vibrating motor. It was translucent, hot pink deepening to cherry red closer to the base. It shimmered with metallic gold flecks of glitter cast in the mold. He withdrew it and scooted closer to them, watching as Chelsea's beautiful hair swished over the backs of Neve's thighs as she still suckled on the hole he'd just fucked.

He tapped the side of the dildo against Chelsea's fingers where they curved over one of Neve's buttocks. She opened that hand, and he placed the dildo in it. Mouth still in Neve's ass, Chelsea switched the dildo on, then stroked it along Neve's pussy. It got the girl whining with ecstasy and her legs labored in the sheets. When Chelsea sunk the large dildo inside her, Neve let out an animal moan, brought her knees together and raised her ass up high.

Ben put himself down on a hip and watched Chelsea ream the molded cock in and out of Neve's pussy. He watched the girl's glimmering pussy lips cling to the shaft, could see the tremble of her membranes from the dildo's rapid vibration. Chelsea worked it in and out of her, obviously feeding off Neve's responses to her actions, and wanting to drive more pleasure into the girl. Soon, Neve's ass was flexing and bouncing, her rump pushing back to meet the deep thrusts of the dildo. Head tilted to the side he could see Neve's breast squished against her own arm, her face buried in the bedding. She cried in ecstasy. Then she came.

Chelsea laughed, spanked one of Neve's ass cheeks, plunged the dildo deep. Neve squirmed away, and Chelsea withdrew it, taking a moment to tease the glistening cock-head shape against the rosebud of Neve's anus. Neve crawled away and tossed herself onto her back, breasts shaking. Her cheeks were flushed, her brow shiny. She ran her tangling hair back from her face.

Chelsea kissed him then, both of them on their hips, one hand stretched out for support. They did it slow and sensual. Chelsea raised the dildo between them, ran her tongue on it, slicking away some of the shine left from deep inside Neve's vagina. She passed it to Ben now, like it was a popsicle they were sharing on a hot summer day. He was reluctant but Chelsea mushed it against his lips, the tip tapping against his teeth. He ran out his tongue and Chelsea swathed it over top; he tasted Neve's pussy. He batted the dildo away and kissed Chelsea again.

"Not too bad, Ben," she whispered. "What else you got?"

CHELSEA PULLED him on top of her again, and he got on his elbows as her knees stroked up his sides. The insides of her thighs closed on his hips. If the guys from school could see him now... It was insane to consider. There was no one he could tell. This was the world's biggest secret—not just to preserve his marriage but to protect his sweet Libby's feelings. She'd never done a thing to him that would deserve the hurt this night would deliver to her.

Despite that truth, there was no turning back, and he let his hips sink down, Chelsea's fingertips guiding the top of his erection so the tip pressed into the slick sleeve of her opening. He sunk himself into her again and she locked her mouth on his. They fucked for a good long while. Hips rolling and rocking, breaths coming fast and hard. His dick ached. Right from his anus, through the bulb of muscle under his balls. The tip of his penis tingled and felt numb. He began to worry he would lose hardness...

But Neve was there to save the day, recovering from her orgasm and looking to join in with some play. The dildo hummed, then he felt the bulb head of it buzzing against his testicles. He stiffened and jerked, but his cock went hard again, and he stabbed it deep inside Chelsea.

Neve ran the dildo lower and he could feel the back of her thumb lift his testicles as she inserted it into Chelsea's anus while he was deep inside her vagina. He could feel the toy's buzz against the underside of his cock right through the thin membrane that kept sex separate from defecation. He grunted and groaned, held himself still inside her while Neve ran the dildo in and out.

Then it was his turn, and he didn't even stop her...

The dildo was withdrawn, the vibrating end of it passing over his balls and making his eyelashes flutter. Then Neve inserted it inside his anus. That had him trying to escape the penetration by thrusting his hips forward, driving every inch he had inside Chelsea, who tittered in his ear, suspecting what her dirty friend was doing to him.

Neve delivered the most unexpected and shocking pleasure to him that way, and he fought it at first but soon succumbed. His cock slipped from Chelsea, but he was frozen in place, on all fours with a dildo in his rectum. Chelsea shimmied underneath him, her face going low, her thick hair spread out on the sheets, slowly tugging out of view as she slunk between his legs.

While Neve used the dildo in his bottom, Chelsea took his cock in her heavenly mouth and kneaded his balls. The pleasure was outrageous. It was pain and discomfort and badness on the ultimate level, but the feeling of her feathery mouth on his sensitive cock and the dildo's expansion of his rectum in combo had him babbling the most bizarre utterances of pleasure. Chelsea took his cock deep, his balls on her chin, and Neve's toy ventured further into him.

It was too much and his stomach collapsed into a hard bar, his breath hitched in his lungs. They had him grabbing on the sheets, trying to pull himself to safety as though the dirty pleasure would drive him to madness like a Lovecraftian horror. He fell and scrambled away...

The two girls laughed at him, watching close together and embracing, on their knees at his feet, their sexy dark silhouettes against the pale of a silky curtain soaking up the outside moonlight. Neve stooped to pull him up by his wrist and Chelsea got on all fours, facing away. He grabbed Chelsea's hips; his heart pounded in his eardrums, his chest tight and a high painful tearing feeling that had him knowing he was at his sexual aerobic maximum. His pulse was too high, his heart rate dangerous, blood pressure pounding fear into his temples. But still he rammed his hardness home in Chelsea's hot slick aperture and gripped her hips. He fucked her hard, making the bed shake and his hips clap against her. Neve hooted in glee and slapped his bottom then Chelsea's. He fucked Chelsea hard as he could. He studied her sexy grace; the swoop of her narrow waist, the swell of her perfect ass, the way her ribs pressed out against her tanned skin. Still, he couldn't make her cry out.

Sweat dripped from his nose, droplets melting onto her back. His skin shone from the effort. His vision grew white. There was a low freight train



roar—it was him. A strange unfamiliar animal bellow coming more from his stomach than his lungs. His scalp tingled. He wasn't sure if he was about to come or suffer an embolism. He'd never felt like this before. He fucked her harder. Chelsea thrashed her hair aside, and he caught a glimpse of her pretty profile; she was laughing.

His stomach tightened, and he grimaced; his hips grew clumsy and uncooperative, his thrusting fell apart and a cramp ripped up the muscles on the left side of his back. He roared. Chelsea dipped forward. His cock popped out.

“Shit,” he cursed, looking down, his vision faded and gray.

Neve grabbed his shining cock and jerked him hard and fast.

“Shoot it Ben, shoot it,” she encouraged him.

Her small hand went like a blur on his shaft and he was aware while the actions of tonight were like the smorgasbord of the porn-site he frequented, the thing in Neve's hand didn't impress the way those other men's did, and he was sure the girls had seen much larger. Doubt washed over him; his size, his ability, his masculinity—and while he'd put forth a valiant effort tonight, he was running on fumes and he knew he'd failed to launch either one of them into ecstasy. He'd just been a bit of fun to them...

He grunted and bucked as he ejaculated in Neve's hand.

“That's it,” she laughed, crushing his cock, swirling her grip on him. Watery pulses dashed from his blushing cock head and onto the curve of Chelsea's taut ass cheek. “Oh, uh-oh,” she sighed, “Ben's running dry...”

He flexed his cock in her hand, trying to squeeze out more, trying to impress this girl he probably couldn't impress, and when he was done, nothing more seeping from his urethra, he fell forward then slipped over the side of Chelsea's body. He lay on his back, panting, covering his face with a forearm. The girls laughed and kissed, Neve getting overtop of Chelsea.

He lay like that for minutes, trying to recover, wishing he would get hard again, but despite the noises of two hot girls pleasuring each other right next to him, his cock lay shriveled and cold, buzzing and numb. As his breaths grew deep and satisfying, he drifted off to sleep...

THROUGH HIS DOZING he was aware of the girls still engaging in play. Like a song in the background, his dreams were sweetened by the sounds of their sighs, their gasps, their laughs, the slaps of palms against soft flesh and the hum of the large dildo.

A shriek of orgasm once roused him to the waking surface, and he saw Chelsea with her legs open, hands clutched in her hair while Neve wiggled that toy buried deep inside Chelsea's pussy. Another time, slurping had his eyes fluttering to pinpoint the source of the odd sound, and he turned his head to see two lithe long-limbed forms next to him, rotated into polar antipodes, Neve on her back with her legs open, Chelsea's legs bestride her face; Chelsea on all fours, Neve's thighs closed against her ears, the two girls delivering oral ministrations to one another, tongues lapping at pussies. Sixty-nine in the vernacular, how he would describe it to his buddies if he were in high school.

But sleep's pull was strong, and his need for recovery urgent. He was in and out.

When he awoke again, it was with a start. He darted up, saw the clock read eleven o'clock. It was a relief. Dread had seized him, thinking he'd slept all night and his worried Libby was on the phone with all their friends trying to locate him. It wasn't too late. And yet, in a way it was...

The actions performed on this bed were undoable, the consequence enormous. A heaviness settled across his shoulders now, extinguishing any male pride stirred up by the legendary conquest of the evening. *Chelsea fucking Cunningham, Ben. You fucked her, dude.*

“I did,” he sighed. Not just Chelsea, but her beautiful friend. Both of them at the same time.

The two beauties were laid out inter-wound beside him; a tangle of long sexy legs, hugging arms, and snarled hair in black and honey plaits. The sight of them sickened him despite the grace of their naked bodies. Moonlight caressed the curves of their knees and hips, the raised mounds of their greasy sexes, Neve’s a dewy thatch of black hair. He buried his face in his hands and groaned.

CHELSEA PATTED his hip with her foot, pedicured nails scratching his skin. “What’s with the hidden face?”

“Nothing.”

“You rested?”

“Yes,” he said into his hands.

“Uh-oh, sounds like Ben doesn’t want to play anymore...”

“It’s not that,” he grumbled, uncovered his face and put his hands on his knees.

Now Neve was stirring as well, he could hear her take a long inhale. “What time is it?” Chelsea told her it was eleven, and Neve said, “What’s he doing?”

Ben said, “It’s getting late.”

“He can’t keep up with us,” Chelsea told Neve quietly.

“I can,” he said, “you know I can. You know what’s wrong.”

“Tell me what’s wrong, Ben,” Chelsea purred in mock compassion.

“I have to go,” he said, straightening but still reluctant to rise.

“Using your conscience as an excuse?”

“Excuse for what?” Now he turned to scowl at her over his shoulder. Chelsea was up on her elbows, unabashedly bare-breasted and eyeing him slyly. Neve clung to her side, looking sleepy.

“If your dick was hard, you’d bend me over and give me what you promised—”

“I can get hard—”

“But it’s not, and you’re worried we’ll suck it and it’ll stay a little shrunken thumb...”

“I can get hard.”

“Show us,” she challenged him.

“It’s eleven.”

“Pumpkin time,” Neve sighed without looking his way.

“My wife will be waiting for me, wondering where I am.”

“It’s only eleven,” Neve said tinged with probably unintended disgust.

“That’s late,” he sighed, buried his face in his hands again.

“Late for little Libby,” Chelsea sighed.

Neve asked, “That’s his wife?”

“Uh-huh. We all went to high school together.”

“Kinky,” Neve said and kissed the side of Chelsea’s breast.

Chelsea laughed, looking down, then wagging her shoulders to make her breasts sway. Neve turned her chin up like a hungry baby and Chelsea moved until her nipple inserted between her friend’s pouted lips.

Ben’s hand went between his legs and grabbed his penis. He pulled it downward, squeezed, exploring whether he could get erect or not. The tip still buzzed all around the pee-hole, the head felt sensitive, his balls ached, but mostly he endured a pervasive air of regret at his actions, his betrayal of his wife who’d never done a bad thing in her life. If he tried he could get hard, he just didn’t want to. But Chelsea would psycho-babble him about his fear being the reason his heart was telling him to flee right now. Maybe she was right, though. Who *was* Ben Todd? Was Ben Todd the stud who fucked two hot girls while his wife watched TV at home? This wasn’t him. This wasn’t his lifestyle.

Now deep and sorrowful regret washed up over him, finding traction on his hurting body and flooding into all of his creases with its awful feeling of sickness...

“Ah, fuck, fuck, fuck,” he sighed, covering his face and shaking his head from side to side.

The bed jostled under him and he felt Chelsea sitting up and scooting close behind him. “Aw, Ben Todd got the bad feelies,” she said poutingly.

“Fuck off,” he said.

“Ooh, a bad boy,” Neve said, “you were right.”

Chelsea’s arms went around him and she kissed his neck. He didn’t push her away. She whispered, “Ben, I told you it was our secret. Libby will never know. At least, I won’t tell her.”

Neve bubbled, “What’s her number, I’ll call her...”

Chelsea snorted laughter through her nose and it whispered over his shoulder and down his sweaty chest. He groaned.

Neve asked, "What's her name again?"

"Libby," Ben groaned.

Neve faked a one sided phone call: "Libby? Hey, it's me....no, I know you don't know me....Neve....N-E-V-E....uh-huh, it's okay, Ben's here....no, he's good, he's good....he's what?....he is....no, he started off hot and hard, but he....you got it, he faded....he does it to you, too?....oh, Libby, I'm so sorry..."

Chelsea laughed again, the sound sweet despite the meanness and she hugged his neck harder. "She's joking, Ben."

"Tell her to shut the fuck up."

"*You* tell her, tough guy."

"You guys are such fucking..."

She tsk-ed in his ear, chastised him, "Oh, Ben, lighten up, it's no big deal..."

"Right, no big deal..."

Now Chelsea's hand moved down into his lap. He covered himself so she wouldn't find out he wasn't erect. Chelsea persisted and he let his hand be guided away by hers. Her nails ran on his balls, tightening his sack, then she toyed with the head of his cock with her thumb and index finger, plucking at it. When it failed to make him erect he put a hand over hers to still her hand. He said, "I'm such a piece of shit."

"You're just a man," she said.

"I'm better than this."

Now she laughed, pulled away from him to flop down next to Neve again. "Ben's special," she said, and they both laughed.

"I don't want to hurt Libby," he said, turning to look over his shoulder at them, unable to hide the pleading from his eyes.

Neve saw, and she softened, her laughter trailing off. Chelsea had a few more chuckles but soon she stopped and the room went quiet.

Chelsea said, "Don't make a big deal about it."

"I'm not," he said. But he was, he really was, even his tone was petulant and sulky.

Chelsea let out an exasperated sigh, turned her eyes up and let her head fall back between her shoulders. It snapped up again, and she fixed him in her gaze. "What if I can make it better?"

“Right. Wave your magic wand? It’s not a movie.”

“Ben, I can make it better.”

“How?”

She studied him, then frowned, gave a look of disinterest and looked away.

He asked again, “How, Chelsea?”

“I’m wasting my time with you,” she said.

“What?—why?”

“You’re... you won’t do it...”

“Do what?”

“Never mind, Ben, it’s over your head.”

“What’s over my head?”

“Forget I said anything.” Now she turned to face Neve, and they looked in each other’s eyes, sharing a solemn moment. Neve nodded.

“You can make it go away?” He’d tried to stay serious to encourage her to divulge the magic spell she would cast to make his hurt go away, but he couldn’t help blurt scoffing laughter.

“I could, Ben,” she said, a strange assuredness in her eyes. Neve’s face, very close to Chelsea’s, also nodded in slow and small increments.

“Yeah,” he laughed again, “I’m sure you could.”

Now he faced away, giving the girls his back, lacing his hands together between his knees. There was an original painting on the wall, something modern and air-brushed, a sexy woman’s face, almost comic book style. He avoided the eyes, let his gaze drift down to the geometric pattern of the area rug that extended out from under the bed and felt soft on the soles of his feet. He drew a deep breath but couldn’t rid himself of the horrible tightness around his heart.

Behind him, Neve asked Chelsea: “What’s this Libby look like?”

Chelsea said, “Little sex pot, like the sexy librarian by day, slut by night...”

He said, “She’s not a slut.”

“She’s just not turned out yet.”

“She’s not like that, Chelsea...”

To Neve, Chelsea said, “She’s kind of short, plump—”

He said, “She’s not *plump*.”

“Not fat, no, not fat at all,” Chelsea continued, “you know, like soft, *sexy* soft. Nice tits, kind of big. *Really* pretty face.”

“She’s so pretty.”

“Glasses, button up shirts. Like a goody-two-shoes.”

He looked over his shoulder at them again, two hot mean girls naked and close, just the sight of them demanding the worst from any man, his most base desire. Chelsea said, “She’s a little mouse. When she talks, you can hardly hear her.”

Neve laughed and then covered her mouth.

Chelsea made mouse noises, going, “Pssh, pssh, pssh,” making Neve laugh harder, then getting under Neve’s silky hair and nibbling on her neck. Ben watched Neve’s brown nipples tighten, the buds scrolling into raised buds. Instead of lust, it inspired heavy sadness in him, knowing how shallow and low he was, how awful he’d let down the woman he loved and who loved him in return.

He asked timidly, “What is it?”

Chelsea ignored him, still nibbling on Neve’s neck and both of them giggling.

“Chelsea,” he asked, “please, what is it?”

She pulled back, both of them on their elbows now, looking at him like a couple of evil ravens and him just a stupid field mouse. “Honestly, Ben, I don’t know if it’d work, and even if we did it, it wouldn’t be easy. It’s not a magic wand...”

“What is it?”

“Tell me, Ben,” she sighed, “tell me what it is that makes tonight so awful for you.”

“I cheated on Libby.”

“Right. But how come I don’t care I cheated on Finn?”

Neve said, “You’re a terrible person,” and put up a hand protectively. Chelsea formed a fist and made like she would backhand her, getting Neve to guess where the strike would come, then sucker-swatting her in the breast and making it jump.

Neve laughed, and complained, soothed and coddled her breast.

“I don’t know,” he said.

Neve blew the setup: “Finn *knows*.”

He asked, “Finn knows what?”

“Finn knows you’re here,” Chelsea said.

Ben frowned. “He knows I’m *here*?”



Chelsea said, "What, you're so hot, some cute guy from high school, so hot I'm going to ruin my marriage?"

"You wanted to do it."

"I wanted to fuck you, yeah. I tell Finn, he says cool."

Now he rubbed the bridge of his nose, sighed, scratched his forehead. "Great, so someone else who knows I cheated on Lib."

"Ben, he doesn't care. I don't care. Neither of us have the same hang-ups you and Lib do. Didn't you have fun tonight?"

Neve clarified: "Before you got gloomy."

Chelsea said, "Yeah, when your dick was rock hard and you were sticking us with it."

He nodded.

"Same with us. If I want to fuck some guy, I can, and if Finn wants to bang some band groupies for backstage tickets, I'm not going to say no."

He fleered. "You're not? Right..."

"He *doesn't*, not anymore. We're not kids, we're twenty-five. Plus, what head's he going to get better than mine? But if he does, he tells me. I love him, he can do what he wants."

"So I should tell Lib we're going to be open?"

Chelsea shook her head, brow lowered in admonishment. "No imagination."

"So what then?"

"Swing with her," Neve interjected.

"God," he laughed, brushing them away with a hand motion, "you obviously don't know Lib."

Chelsea said, "Neve had a boyfriend, we used to swing, only we didn't nerd out and call it swinging we just called it being cool cats."

"I was nerding it up for *him*," Neve said close to Chelsea, and she smiled.

Neve said to him now, "My boyfriend's been with her, I was with Finn, all four of us were crawling over each other like a litter of newborn pups. Nobody sweats it."

He laughed even more heartily now, then met Chelsea's gaze, and shook his head. "Tell your friend Libby's never going to go for that."

"I don't know that, Ben. You ever asked her?"

"I don't need to. I sure hope this isn't your magic solution to making it all better."

“It could be if you weren’t so resistant.”

“I’m not resistant. I *know* she won’t. I know I can’t lift up a car, I don’t have to put my hands under the bumper and see if I’m right or not.”

Neve’s eyes were distant, and she murmured, “There’re those women who can lift a car off their baby, adrenalin or whatever.”

“Desperate times, Ben, Neve’s right. You don’t think you can lift a car till you have to do it.”

Now he covered his face with both hands again and sighed heavily, the long exhale close to becoming sobs. One of the girls prodded his back with a toe.

“What?” He turned to regard them again.

Chelsea said, “How about it?”

“How about what?”

“If Finn sleeps with Libby, you two will be even. You will be returned to neutral. You’ll go back to the way you guys were, I guarantee it. And both of you will be happy. Most importantly: you’ll be free.”

“Chelsea, sweetheart,” he said with elaborate condescension, “Libby will *never* sleep with Finn.”

“But if she did...?”

“I don’t want that,” he sighed, looking into the airbrushed eyes.

“I don’t care if you do or don’t, Ben, I was actually interested in making you feel better. I had fun tonight, so did Neve...”

“I did...”

“Both of us are prob gonna smoke another bowl and watch some movies since your dick is bailing on us. Tomorrow Finn will ask how my night was and I’ll tell him Ben Todd wasn’t the fuck I thought he’d be, but he wasn’t half bad.”

“Gee, thanks.”

“Point is, tonight’s nothing to me more than some pleasure. Like a really good hot yoga class...”

Neve said, “Ooh, I *love* hot yoga...”

“And I just hate that you don’t see it the same way. It sucks for you, but it doesn’t have to.”

He locked eyes with the painting and listened to the enormous pregnant quiet in the room. The moment grew heavy and long and felt like it should end with a nerve-jangling explosion. He couldn’t stand it. He whispered, “She’s never been with another man. Only me.”

There was a pause, then Chelsea said, “Aw, poor Libby,” and both girls laughed. “No offense. You’re great, Ben, but she’s a beautiful girl who could have had a lot of fun.”

“She’s not like that.”

Neve said, “She doesn’t like to have fun?”

Chelsea said, “She’s kind of stuck up.”

Ben said, “No, she’s not.”

“You’re right, that’s not the right thing. There’s something stuck *up* her.”

Neve asked, “Up her butt?” Both girls snorted, then let loose with a hearty laugh.

Chelsea said, “She’s got a broomstick stuck up her...”

“She’s just stiff,” Ben said. “Shy.”

“You know, Ben, it might be good for her. You never got her to do some of the things you like. No blow jobs?... Maybe if she loosened up, your own sex life could, you know, *blossom*...”

“I don’t want her to have sex with someone else.”

Neve said to Chelsea, “I thought you said he was a nice guy?”

“Geez, I know, huh? Ben, that’s not nice. You just fucked us and you don’t want your Libby to have any fun? It’s all about you?...”

“No, I love her...”

“Nice guy Ben I knew from high school was caring and supportive. Hey, ever wonder if you don’t turn Lib’s crank?”

“I turn her crank.”

Neve said, “Could you imagine if Libby liked giving blow jobs to another man but not to Ben...?”

Both of them thought this was hilarious and collected one another’s hands so they could regale in unison. When they noticed Ben didn’t join in on the hilarity, they dipped their chins in theatrical farouche. “We’re kidding, Ben,” Neve said.

“You don’t know my Libby,” he said. “You think it’s funny what you’re saying, but Libby is a good person...”

“Better than us?”

“*You* wouldn’t think so, but she is...”

His honest words brought more sniggering.

“It’s true,” he said, wasting his time pleading to these two unflappable vixens who collapsed against one another to celebrate the hilarity that was

Ben Todd's suffering.

IN CHELSEA and Finn's shower he scrubbed himself scrupulously. Water turned as hot as he could stand it, he shampooed twice and used conditioner once, doing his pubic hair too. He used bar soap all over his body, then a few handfuls of liquid soap.

A man's brand. Finn's.

He used the things that Chelsea's husband used to clean himself. There was shampoo and soap, strong manly deodorant brands. A back loofah. He could picture Finn raking his own back, naked in the shower, cleaning himself for a night with Lib... There was a razor, too, and since it was in the shower where there was no mirror he imagined it was for pubic hair. Chelsea shaved down there, did Finn as well? Did he want to find out?...

The idea that he could absolve himself of his sins by allowing his wife—no, *encouraging* his wife, or tricking her even, into some sort of swinging foursome was ludicrous. He didn't deny that he could see how it would work, but it was *insane*.

For one thing, Libby would never go for it. Of all the people in the world who could be engaging in kinky open-ended marriages, Libby was at the bottom of the list. Straight-laced and squeaky clean, she'd been that way since he knew her in public school. And he didn't want to share her. The idea that Finn would be with his wife was disgusting. That lean guy with all his tattoos pressing up against soft and innocent Libby? No way. She would beat her fists on his chest, call him a masher, and despite that, why would he *want* that to happen?

*Because it could save your marriage...*

Libby hadn't been with anyone but him, and he liked it that way. But then again, some things the girls said were true too. There were things Libby wouldn't do. Things he wouldn't even bring up to Libby to try out of embarrassment. She didn't want to use her mouth on him. She tried, but she said it made her feel self-conscious. He let her go. The one year he spent without her he'd had two girlfriends both who had no qualms about sexual activity, oral or otherwise. He'd had anal sex with one of them. But those girls weren't sweethearts like Libby, and so he settled on the girl that made his heart beat despite some of her hang ups. There was so much good in that woman he could overlook her milk and cookies attitude toward sex. And she liked making love with him, they did it at least twice a week. The lights needed to be off and you had to be careful not to say something or do something that might embarrass her...

He spritzed another dollop of clear amber gel soap into his palm. It smelled like pine and spruce and talc. He held the cup of his palm under his nose. This would be what Libby smelled. These were the grooming products of another man. Another man proposed to him that would sleep with his wife for the benefit of saving Ben from the damage to his marriage due to his horrible sins.

It was just fun; it was just sex.

*What happened tonight wasn't more to me than a good session of hot yoga.*

Could it be like that? Could sex just be something they did for fun? He tried to picture Libby with Finn. Lib backing away from him until her butt bumped into the kitchen cupboards. Finn looming over, giving her that steady eye the cool guys do, coming in for a kiss. Libby, horrified, hands up to her chest in fearful protection, pulling back her chin, but not turning away...

Now he could see the two of them kissing, Finn putting his hand on Libby's neck...

He shook it off, physically shaking his head to clear away those thoughts. His heart was racing with just the mere *consideration*. There was no way he could do it. Way, way, way too crazy...

COMING down the stairs fully dressed, shirt tucked in, he could hear the girls talking low and tittering. Weed hung heavy in the air. He found them lounging on the cushy couches where tonight's badness had begun. The couch they were on was the largest one, a squat comfy L shape, and they lay with their two heads together at the corner, watching up at the retractible big screen TV ascended from the huge armoire where it usually remained hidden. An old black and white movie played and the girls' weed-sleepy eyes watched. They tittered again, making comments about what they were seeing.

Neve wore a black hoody sweatshirt with a cartoon logo, bikini panties, and comfy looking socks pulled up to her thin tanned knees. Chelsea relaxed in panties and a men's flannel shirt, a white tank underneath.

"Hey, Ben," Neve said, waving her fingers at him, "come sit with us..."

He walked near them, intending—no matter what—not to stay. Chelsea rubbed his knee with her bare toes. When he looked down, she said, "You get our smell off?"

He nodded, his face tightening to grim.

Chelsea returned her attention to the movie. He asked, "What are you watching?"

Chelsea said, "Keys to the City."

Neve added: "1950."

He watched a good-looking older man struggle a large wooden box down from a ramp, flipping it over with a longshoreman's hook. There was a crowd gathered, applauding this public spectacle. Ben said, "Is that Charlton Heston?"

The look he received from both of them was pure scorn. They said in unison: “Clark Gable.”

“Sorry,” he said, “that’s who I meant, anyway, I just mixed up his name.”

“The female lead is Loretta Young. Mr. Gable there is about fifty and she’s in her early thirties. This is sweet romantic fluff, but there’s a dirty bathwater grime flowing in its veins...”

Neve turned up her nose like she was disgusted, knowing where this story was going.

Chelsea said, “They were in *Call of the Wild* together fifteen years before this, 1935, and let’s just say Loretta Young has a fifteen-year-old daughter...”

Neve clutched her hands to her chest, and gasped, “*Scandaloso...*”

Chelsea said, “Clark was married back in ’35 and Loretta was a squeaky clean pup of twenty, and if you believe her later accounts—”

“Hashtag me-too,” Neve interjected.

Chelsea agreed, “Hashtag me-too, Loretta claimed sex with that handsome devil,” she leveled a pointed finger at the actor on the screen, “wasn’t consensual...”

“Oh,” Neve proclaimed again, “*scandaloso...*”

“Why are you watching it then?”

She frowned like it was the stupidest question ever, said, “We’re watching their faces. Like, did C.G. know Loretta’s kid was his? Did L.Y. grit her teeth through every scene with the man who took advantage of her and knocked her up? Did she maybe, gasp, have feelings for the man? Good ones, bad ones...? Did she ever want to hurt him? Like, we’re studying their faces, seeing what’s betrayed in their eyes...”

He watched for a minute with his arms crossed. “Creepy,” he said.

Chelsea said, “Creepy. But there she is, Ms. Young, my fine female warrior doing her job in a man’s world.”

“Hard core, bro,” Neve said.

They tried bumping their knuckles together sleepily and without looking but missed three times and then couldn’t stop giggling.

Chelsea said, “Or who knows...? Maybe there was still something about Clark. A woman’s mind...”

Neve turned her face up so she could see Ben’s. She said, “We can be dark.”



Both girls laughed and then watched a minute of action on the screen.

Chelsea tapped his knee again with her toes and when he looked she said, "Finn told me he thinks your wife has a little crush on him."

Ben laughed. "No, she doesn't. She doesn't get crushes..."

Both girls turned their heads awkwardly, practically looking at each other upside down in their pillows, cheeks dimpling with smirks. Chelsea said, "Sure, she's just a dry husk of a woman who's only turned on by Ben Todd."

He groaned. "Finn's not her type."

"What, cause he doesn't read?"

"Yeah, no offense."

Chelsea smiled. "You only interested in girls that buy and sell luxury craft?—"

"—and cheat on their spouses..." Neve added.

The two girls howled with laughter.

"Libby's timid, and she's so good. She'd never cheat—"

"I think she would," Chelsea interjected dourly.

"She wouldn't. And Finn isn't her type."

"I can't help you, Ben," Chelsea said, shrugging her shoulders, laying there and showing him her palms. "It's on the table. I'm offering salvation, it's up to you if you want to advance your marriage, let Lib loosen up a bit, or if you want to curl up and bear the burden of what you've done, let it crush your time with your wife 'cause it's all you can think of. Shit, Ben, what we did tonight was a blast. You were a lot of fun—"

Neve said, "You were," agreeing but not taking her eyes from the movie.

"Not a big deal," Chels continued, "and I'm telling you what Finn told me: just the other day he said Libby gives him lovey eyes."

"No, she doesn't." He blurted a raspberry, scoffing at the ridiculous idea.

"Come to the dark side, Ben," Neve said in a horror movie voice, still watching the screen then laughing. Chelsea joined in.

"Libby would never..."

Chelsea sighed, told Neve to pause the movie and then sat up and stretched. "Bring it in, Benjamin," she sighed and put her arms out to him. He dipped and hugged her and she rubbed his back. "Great night, dude," she said.

When she broke the embrace, she straightened her shirt, said, “Now say bye to your Auntie Neve, she goes back to B.C. tomorrow.”

He shuffled past Chels and got close to Neve who reached out and gave him a hug too. “Bye, Ben,” she said near his ear. “Maybe I’ll see you later in the summer.”

Now he stood up, adjusted his pants, tried to act as chill as he could, said, “I’ll let myself out.”

The two girls gave him another soft bye and went back to their movie, lounging with the tops of their heads almost together. He left the room, walking backward and studying them. Their long bare legs, their casual coolness and confidence. They talked and laughed, Neve wagged a finger at Clark Gable. They were happy and content and satisfied. *And Finn knew what his wife did tonight...*

As he slipped his shoes back on, he resisted the urge to say good night again because he didn’t figure that’s what a cool guy did. He was having to feel his way out here, but he *was* a quick learner...

IT WAS a short stroll down Chelsea's Street to Boardwalk Drive, over one block, then up their street. He made his way solemnly, his head dipped in funereal melancholy. His canines worked over the inside of his cheek as he worried the thoughts of the evening. All those things he'd done. *Why* did he do them?

*You know why. You wanted to since you got your first hair on your scrotum...*

Chelsea Cunningham had been in his sexual thoughts from the moment he'd become a young man. How could he resist her when she wanted it so bad? That didn't make it okay, but at least it could stop the awful lamentation of the *Why, why, why, oh, why, did I do it?*

*You know why you did it.* Just like Chelsea said, You're just a man. A man who thought he was better than he was. Chelsea provoked something within him, fired up his masculine engines and drove him remotely like a gleeful young girl with the remote control to her big brother's RC monster truck. Making him turn left, making him turn right, making him do things he wouldn't normally do...

Three houses down from his he stopped short.

He'd walked because he told Libby he was going to take the subway into the city—didn't want her to find out his truck was parked just one street over. That was a surefire way to get caught. Parked behind his truck was a familiar red VW Beetle.

Now his head dipped lower, and he crossed over to the opposite side of the street and continued on until he was directly across from his house. It was dark now, and he was under the shade of a maple tree's canopy,

shielding him from the overhead streetlight. He leaned in the shadows against the trunk and watched the lit up windows of his house.

Coming into the front hallway now—seen through the square window set in the front door, like watching this on TV—he saw the cast members of this sad show: his beautiful and innocent wife, smiling, looking up at her dad, and her mom was there too, coming along now behind, looking like she was slipping feet into loafers. Their visit was over, they were leaving. It was perfect timing because the last thing he needed right now was coming face-to-face with them. How would he look in their eyes?

“Ah, fuck,” he groaned, rubbing at his forehead.

Libby was hugging her parents, they all patted each other’s arms, now cheeks were being kissed. Libby opened the front door, and her father stepped down onto the stoop.

Before he knew what he was doing, Ben was strolling out from under the protection of the tree and into the light. Each step brought him closer to his front door, his heart wrenching, his insides twisting, guilt and shame and regret gaining the weight of an anvil inside him. But physically he resisted, and with great effort produced the opposite reaction in his body, standing straighter, raising his eyebrows, brightening his face. Manufacturing the look of a guy who was out at work tonight, just getting home to see his in-laws and was happy about it. The alternative was to sink into the shadows below that tree, curl and fester, let his badness suppurate.

“Hey, there,” he shouted out and gave a wave as he stepped onto the driveway, walking past Rich and Bev’s vintage Volkswagen.

“Hey, there he is, there’s the champ,” Libby’s dad said.

“Hi, Ben,” Libby’s mother said, beaming past Lib’s shoulder, truly happy to see him.

“Hey, baby,” Libby said. “You’re late.”

“Sorry, sorry,” he said, “I didn’t think I would be...”

“Leave the man alone, sunshine,” Rich said, “the guy’s busy out there working, making a living.” He put out a hand. “Come here, kid...”

Ben’s hand went out to shake, and he felt an instant stiffness inside him. Rich clasped hands, pulled him into a hug and slapped his back. “Good to see you, Ben boy...”

“Hey, Rich, good to see you...”

The short time they embraced came with the thrill of awful discovery. Rich would step back and smell his hand that had just held Ben’s....he

would say I smell pussy....no, *two* pussies... Bev would gasp and clutch her poor daughter, console her, they would cry that they'd thought Ben Todd was one of the good ones...

But after they shook and hugged, they came apart and his father-in-law met his eye and winked. "Lib says you just bought a yacht."

"Bought and sold already," he said, acting confident.

"Good work, kid," Rich said.

"What are you guys doing here?"

Bev said, "We came in to the city to go for dinner, we were on our way home and thought we'd bring you guys some dessert."

"Out for dinner why?"

Rich nudged him. "Man doesn't need a reason to surprise his wife, does he?"

"No, he doesn't," Ben said, and Rich clapped him on the arm. "Sorry I missed you guys. Lib should've called..."

Libby said, "Dad wouldn't let me."

"Like I said, you're out working, and these days it doesn't cut it to be nine-to-five, you gotta go wherever or whenever the action is, am I right, Ben?"

"You're right," he said.

"All right, listen, we gotta go," Rich said, clapped his hands for Bev to hurry along and join him. She gave Libby another kiss on the cheek, they embraced, then she came down the stairs and Ben met her for his own turn. He gripped Libby's mom's arms, kissed both cheeks, got the pats on his back she'd always give him. He'd known the Sanders since he was seven. Had seen them together as a couple when they weren't much older than he and Libby were now. Been to their house so many times, for so many functions, had always been the good kid that hung around and did the dishes and talked to Bev, was the one who'd sworn to do right by their daughter... The effort to look in their eyes was killing him.

He stepped up onto the stoop and slung his arm around Libby's waist and held her to him. He drew in a deep breath and held it, waiting for the explosive question: *Why do you smell like another woman?* And then, lit up in her parents' Beetle's headlights, Lib would turn and beat her fists on him and he would fall and crumple and cry and die.

Instead, Libby said, "Mm, you smell good," and rested her head on his shoulder as her parents backed out of the driveway.

IN BED with Libby he was content to sleep with her in his arms. The two of them curled against each other like spoons, his Libby folded against his stomach, his arm around her, both her hands clutched to his. She slept peacefully. His heart beat slow and steady in his ears. Not fast but *way* too strong.

*What if you just told her?*

*Yeah, right, how do you see that going?*

Pretty much just like he'd pictured it on the stoop: Lib would bleat and cry, wail, pack her things and flee to her parents' house.

*Kick you out more likely.*

Maybe both. Kick him out, then go stay with her parents. He wouldn't blame her. Libby didn't deserve to be hurt.

So what else could he do? Would time heal the wounds? A week from now would he be able to breathe fully again? Right now it was like his rib cage had locked into place, his lungs had to function under the reduced accommodation. *Shallow* breaths. Almost like he didn't *deserve* them. And he didn't. He deserved to suffocate and die for what he'd done.

As much as he hated himself, if Libby found out what he'd done, she would hate him too, and even more.

So what then? Go for a dinner party to the Slade's house, maybe everybody gets in the hot tub after? Next thing, swim suits are off, or maybe car keys are plopped in a dish... Why would we do that, Ben? Isn't there only the four of us here? Fifty-fifty chance, Libby. It's either me or Finn, but you'll be sleeping with one of us. Sleeping, Ben? Uh-huh, oh, look at this, Lib, those are Finn's keys you picked...

He tightened his thighs. Is that how it worked? Was that how it was when Neve and her boyfriend came over for a summertime barbecue at the Slade's? Was it eat and then fuck? Did Finn watch as Neve's boyfriend fucked Chelsea? Then what, it was their turn? Chelsea and Neve's boyfriend watching as Finn fucked Neve? Or did they all just go at the same time?

*We crawled around on the bed like newborn pups...*

It got him shaking his head again to clear away that thought, squeezing his grip on one of Libby's little sleeping hands.

"Oh, Libby," he sighed. "What did I do?"

Now he tried a new image.

They're at a party, it's summertime, but it's nighttime. They've all had succotash and barbecued chicken, he's had a few beers, and Libby... Libby's had a few more glasses of wine than she's used to. Somebody says *Hey, let's get in the hot tub*.

Chelsea says, "All right, but no swimsuits."

Libby squeals, "Oh, no way..." Her cheeks blush harder.

Chelsea says, "No peeking, everybody turn around..." Chelsea's not overplaying it, and not acting too forward, she's playing it just right.

Somehow, the wine has worked its magic, and his demure wife is getting a little frisky. She's hiding in the bushes and stripping down, demanding everybody turn away as she climbs into the hot tub with her hands over those precious boobs.

Maybe now the talk gets a little frisky. Chelsea confides, Hey, this one time Finn and I had sex in the bushes at a resort in Mexico...

Lib can't believe it. "Oh, no, you didn't..."

"Oh, we did, it was crazy... Where's the craziest you've done it, Libby?..."

"In a hotel..."

"In a hotel...? Was it in the hotel's bushes?..."

"No, it was in a... hotel *room*..."

"You've never done it somewhere crazy, Libby?"

"No, never!"

Chelsea purrs, "Like, never in a... *hot tub*?"

Now he could picture Finn sidling up to his wife, both of them naked under the water. Libby is smiling expectantly, waiting for the joke to be over, but Finn's not backing away, instead he's leaning in to kiss her, and

she's smiling, darting her eyes sideways to her husband, waiting for Ben to jump in and stop Finn. Only Ben doesn't stop him. Ben is getting saved. Ben is going to let Libby experiment. And when it's done, what then?

Now it's the morning after, and Libby's embarrassed. "I can't believe I did that, Ben."

He says, "It's okay, sweetheart. It's totally okay."

"It's not okay, Ben, that was *crazy!*"

"I love you more than ever, Libby. You didn't do a thing wrong..."

And that's that. *You had sex with Finn, I had sex with Chelsea. Whatever it is, everything's okay...*

*What if she wants that lifestyle?*

*There's no way she would want that lifestyle, Ben, get real.* It's a onetime thing. Finn sleeps with her, Even-Steven. Ben gets his life back.

He had to dip his hips backward now, because for some reason the bizarre but erotic movie he'd just conjured in his head brought hardness between his legs again. And here he was thinking he'd been depleted. He should take a picture right now, send it to Chelsea, say See? *I went home for my wife, you're lucky, because I could've gone all night, I'm a lot more than you can handle.*

Now he was slipping out from the bed, gathering his phone from the night table and creeping into the bathroom. He opened up his messenger and finger-hovered, trying to determine if this was the right thing or not. He gripped his erection through his pants. Squeezed it hard.

He texted.

**Ben:** how would this work?



PART 4  
ROCKET FUEL

TUESDAY, JULY 2

THE BREAKFAST DATE was with Chelsea but it was Finn who showed up. Ten o'clock in the morning, and Ben was sitting in a quiet booth near the rear of the agreed-upon café, Rocket Fuel in Queen West, a place where a married man could meet a married woman and have privacy, one far from where Libby and her friends worked and lived. It was the Tuesday after the long weekend and the neighborhood was quiet. He'd parked out front, and from where he sat inside the cafe he could see his truck. Now there was a motorcycle sandwiching behind his bumper, and he could tell the rider was Chelsea's husband.

His guts did a noisy rollover, he could hear a groaning squish from behind his belt buckle, and shifted uncomfortably. The palms of his hands had gone damp but freezing cold. His fingers tingled. It got him shifting in the booth, looking around as a panic *Flee!* message broadcast through his brainstem. *Was there a back door? Maybe he could duck out before it was too late...*

But Finn wasn't here to punch his head in. If Finn wanted to do that, he knew where Ben lived and he wouldn't have to get on his motorcycle to go and do it, he could just march one street over.

As he watched the rider dismount, he fidgeted. Pulling up on his belt, rotating his chin around and flexing his neck, tugging at the collar of his shirt. He'd dressed to impress, thinking he was going to have a coffee with Chelsea. Clean pressed shirt, sporty tie, cotton chinos, spiffy leather boots. Everything about him made him self-conscious right now. The clothes he wore, this intimate spot deep in the cafe he'd chosen. It was a sunny day, there was sidewalk seating, but he'd chosen this cozy booth near the back

of the place, sitting in a padded leather booth with his tiny ten-dollar cup of espresso.

The rider used both hands to pull up on the half-helmet, and shook out his long black hair, shaved at the sides, cut ragged and uneven. It was Finn, there was no doubt about it. And no sign of Chelsea...

Finn held the helmet against his chest like a basketball he was looking to pass, dipped at the knees to read Ben's license plate, confirming it was his wife's friend's truck, then tucked the helmet into the pickup's bed.

Now Finn was coming into the café, nodding and smirking to a table of four well-dressed women that had been watching him closely. One of the bolder ones said something likely sassy to him, and he laughed and pointed at her. All the women turned their heads to watch him enter. Finn stepped into the dim, stopping at the door and scanning the tables. The place was at a quarter of its occupancy and Ben was easy to spot, everyone else with any sense taking up the sunshine spots on the sidewalk. Finn spotted him, and his gaunt face changed instantly to recognition and happiness. Finn mouthed, *Hey*, and waved. He sauntered through the empty tables, tromped the step to the raised platform where the booths were, threw himself into the booth opposite Ben. "Beauty day, eh?"

"It is," Ben said quietly.

Finn bounced around while getting comfortable, stretching out in the leather banquette then tweaking a menu over to himself so he could read it. He asked Ben, "What did you get?"

"Espresso."

"Ooh, sounds good, I'll have that," he said. Then he was raising an arm, waving to the busy carousel in the center of the big restaurant where the baristas resided. Ben watched Finn's muscles move under all the tattoos on his skin. The guy had some good muscle on him, and now Ben wondered what he looked like with his shirt off. He shook the thought away, because it came abruptly and unwanted. Today Finn wore a plain black T-shirt with a V-neck that clung to his body. It showed the sharp ridges of his body. He was slim but muscular, with broad bulging shoulders.

As the waitress made her way to their table, Ben tried to be casual, looking out to the bright street at Finn's bike, saying, "Malevolent Custom?—what is it, the Lucifer? Built on a Harley Night Train, right?"

Finn put an elbow on the back of the booth's bench and looked out the window behind him. "You got it," he said. Then turning back said, "You

ride?”

“No,” he said. “I don’t. I just bought bikes before, I know two brothers in Libya who would kill for a bike like yours.”

“Literally kill?” Finn asked, eyebrows going up in a worried tent.

Ben shrugged. “Yeah, maybe,” he said then laughed. “They don’t have to, they got me. They say they want something and I deliver it.”

Finn let out an honest laugh and leaned forward, elbows onto the table, getting close to Ben and smiling. He said, “Kind of why we’re here, isn’t it?”

Ben’s mouth opened, but no response came, and then it was too late, the waitress standing at the side of their table. She had a flirty bounce she didn’t have when she took Ben’s order, liking the cut of bad boy Finn’s jib. Out of the context of his home at last weekend’s block party, Finn did seem different now. He *was* good-looking, but not drop-dead gorgeous. His face was narrow, nose largish, but he had a muscular neck and a pronounced jawline. That crazy shaggy-shaved hairdo took something to pull off, and Finn did. The clothes he wore were fashionable, hip, expensive, too. Then there was the motorcycle. Then there were the tattoos... And he did have an easy-going confidence, one that exuded all kinds of things at once: maybe menace, but it was cushioned in an immediate amiability, a strange allure that made you eager to have him like you.

Finn said to the waitress, “Can I get an espresso like my buddy’s,” pointing to Ben’s, “with lemon. Actually make it two, and bring Ben another one, please. And then put the whole thing on my bill...”

“Oh, hey, no, I got it,” Ben said and then felt stupid. What did that mean?—*Oh, I fucked your wife on the long weekend, let me get the coffees, it’s the least I could do...*

Finn said, “Yeah, all on my bill—awesome day out there, eh?”

“It was *such* a long winter,” the girl said smiling, lingering.

Now Finn was leaning closer to her, talking about the weather and how awful the winter was, how great it was to see the spring turn into a great summer, and he had the girl telling him what her plans were, where she was going to go camping, the girl getting comfortable and leaning a hip against the bench on the side where Finn sat, even draping her hand over the rest.

Now Ben could see it in a different way—see *Finn* in a different way. He could see the charm, could see the appeal. Maybe it made sense that Chelsea was with a guy like this. Didn’t she say all those high school jocks

were duds? She found herself an official member of the Cool Guy Club. No bravado, not a poser, the guy worked with famous bands, had a good job, and had a way with people...

"...totally cool," Finn was saying to the smitten girl now as she backed away from the table, practically beaming. She spun on her heel and trotted back to prepare their espressos.

And Finn was too cool to drop a lewd remark and comment on the blatant perkiness of the girl's twenty-year-old ass. Instead just rubbing his own arms, elbows on the table, face close to Ben's again. In a low voice, he said, "Hear you had a great Saturday."

Ben's lips went tight and he backed away. "What did she tell you?"

"Chelsea?... Said you came by for dinner, Neve was there. Said you guys had a blast."

"We did," he said stiffly.

Finn cocked his head and said, "I know you guys banged," clapping his hands on the backs of his arms.

"Okay..."

"Yeah, she told you I was cool...?"

"She did."

"It's totally cool, Ben." Finn lowered his gaze, trying to fix Ben in it. His eyes were dark, almost black, and maybe he even wore eyeliner, it was hard to tell, but looking in his eyes had a magnetic pull.

Ben murmured, "Okay," again, looked sheepishly off to the barista carousel as the coffee grinder kicked up.

Finn said, "Hey, Ben, seriously."

"Okay," he said, "it's just weird."

Finn shrugged, said, "What do you think of Neve?"

"She was nice..."

"Nice? Yeah, Neve's a sweetheart. Totally nice times ten. She makes awesome succotash, I was so sorry I missed it."

"You were in Peterborough?"

"Yeah, big outdoor summer concert there. Cooter was playing, they had some small acts too, it was tight..."

Ben nodded, his eyes drifting off to the side again, watching the barista instead of meeting Finn's gaze.

Finn said, "So Chelsea told me about Libby."

"What did she tell you?"

“That you kinda want to bring her in...”

“Yeah, kind of....”

Finn nodded, and there was still this uncomfortable brittle space between them, and Ben couldn't get over that he was sitting here talking to another man about having sex with his wife.

Finn sensed that and chuckled, leaned back against the leather banquette. He drummed his fingers on the table, his legs gone out wide. He said, “Chelsea's a wildcat.”

“She is.”

“There's nobody like her.”

“No.”

Finn said, “You wanted to do that with her since high school?”

He nodded.

“That's totally awesome. Man, look what happened, you wanted something and you got it...”

He slumped. “Yeah, but now I feel bad...”

“Chelsea told me you caught a bad case of the guilts.”

He arched his back, craned his neck to look up at the black-painted ceiling. He rested his chin in his palms, but still avoided Finn's gaze. “She said she would meet me here today.”

Finn leaned forward again. “She said I should go, that I should make you feel good about this.”

“Good about what?”

“Look, Ben, Libby is awesome. I totally dig Lib.”

Ben's stomach tightened hearing another man say nice things about his wife in contemplation that all four of them may get together to have some kind of group sex. His heart rate kicked up and he shook his head, pushed thumbs into his eyeballs and groaned.

“What's up?”

Ben moaned, “There's just *no* way this is going to work...”

“I think it'll work,” Finn said, easing back now at the sound of incoming clinking espresso cups on saucers. The waitress was there, their three drinks on a tray held at her shoulder. She set them down, engaged in a little banter with Finn again then sashayed off. Finn sipped his espresso, and Ben followed suit.

Finn said, “It's totally doable, Ben. If you're into it.”

“Libby won't be,” he said.

“That’s cool, too. She doesn’t want to, we won’t make her. It’s not like that.”

He groaned again.

“What is it?... The guilt?”

“I shouldn’t have done what I did.”

“I get it,” Finn said. “Yup, you probably shouldn’t have, not if you feel this bad after. You should’ve cleared it with her.”

“Libby?”

“I know, you’re gonna say she would kick you out of the house for even asking...”

“I can’t believe I cheated on her.”

“You did,” Finn said. “But if you think Libby might do this, Chelsea’s right, it could restore you guys...”

“I don’t think that. Chelsea thinks that.”

Finn laughed. “Chelsea’s full of crazy ideas. I think she’s right in this case though.”

“I feel like I’m wasting your time. There’s no way we’ll get Libby to do anything. You don’t know her. It’s ludicrous. The other night I fantasized about it, and I can see how it would work, but sitting here with you and talking about it I realize how stupid it sounds...”

“Well, whatever, then,” Finn said, putting his palms up for a second then sipping his espresso. “Maybe she’d go for it, maybe she wouldn’t. I’d like to make a suggestion.”

“What’s that?”

“Let me handle it.”

Ben looked up, blinking, got pulled into his eyes. “What are you gonna do?”

“I wasn’t joking about Libby being a sweetheart, Ben. I had so much fun with her at your place. Like teaching her to dance?... She’s so cute, she really is. Just a little mouse.”

“She is, I know she is. She’s so wonderful.”

“Lib had a good time with me, Ben. I could see it in her eyes.”

“Chelsea said you thought she has a crush on you.”

“I think she does,” he said, wincing in an ameliorative way.

“I don’t think she does.”

Finn shrugged it off. “I think that’s the way we do it.”

“Do what? Get her to...?”

“Get her to do the same thing you did.”

He clutched his stomach. “I don’t want that,” he said.

“Yes, you do. You’re going to have to face it. If you think that’s gonna make the guilt go away, you have to be honest with yourself.”

His lips pursed as the enormity of what was being proposed began to lap at his feet. “Not... not with two guys or anything...”

“Like you with two girls, Chelsea and Neve? No, she won’t want that at first. But I just mean you, Ben, *you* want *your* wife to cheat on you... You have to face it head on.”

There it was, the ugly truth jostling on a bed of rice like vomited octopus. “God,” he said, “I can’t do it. I don’t want to do that...”

“You *could* be honest with her, tell her what you did.”

“She’ll kill me, she’ll hate me... just the idea of seeing her upset, seeing the disappointment in her eyes...”

“It’s up to you, Ben. I’m telling you I think maybe you don’t know Libby as well as you do.”

“Oh, come on, of course I do. I’ve known her since we were like seven years old. I’m married to her, for fuck’s sake.”

“So you know ninety-nine percent of her... I’m not challenging you, Ben. I just mean there are probably things in her that she keeps from you.”

“I hope not,” he said.

“Every woman does. Look, Chelsea’s a wildcat, I just said it, you agreed. She does crazy things sometimes, make me scratch my head and wonder about her sanity. She’s free and she’s open... I don’t know her a hundred percent. We’ve done *everything*. We share *everything*. I guarantee you there’s still a part of her I don’t know.”

“That’s a scary thought,” he said.

Finn laughed. “Keeps me up at night.”

Ben sipped his espresso, met Finn’s gaze. “So you think you could bring Libby around?”

“Tell me you’re cool with it.”

“I don’t think I am.”

“Then I’m not gonna do it, Ben.”

He puffed out his cheeks, could feel the cold snakes of regret begin to slither through him, his chance at absolution putting on its coat and hat and preparing to leave. “Tell me what you would do.”



“Let me spend time with her. Let me get to know her. It’s not like we’re just going to invite you guys over and we’re all going to get naked and jump in the hot tub. Some people are like that, but I don’t think Libby is.”

“She’s not.”

“So let me get to know her. I’ll tell you if she’s going to go for it or not, and we can decide then.”

“You just want to get to know her?”

“Yeah. I’d love to spend time with her. She seems like a really awesome girl.”

“She is. She’s so awesome. She’s innocent...”

“Yeah, she is, she’s totally innocent.”

Ben eased back from the table, studied the bitter remnants of his drink. He rattled the coffee cup on the saucer a little, his brow lowering as he considered it. There was a traitorous arousal in his underwear. He wanted to reach down and adjust it but wouldn’t do that with Finn sitting here, didn’t want to give away that despite the horror of his treachery the idea of Finn seducing his wife produced the oddest arousal. He didn’t know what that was about. Why would he get aroused at the idea of another man going out with his wife? Why would he get aroused by the idea of his sweet Libby enjoying spending time with another man? How was he getting hard despite the sick twisting in his stomach? His chest had gone tight, his heart beat struggling against the constriction. The mere idea of surrendering the most precious thing in his life to another man was the worst thing imaginable...

He leaned forward again, slipped a hand under the table and tugged at his pant leg. He said to Finn, “Okay. I can still say no?”

“You can.”

“Okay, I want you to get close to her.”

Finn smiled. “It’s as good as done, Ben.”

## AFTERWORD

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